

CITY: Pg 2

Drastic drop in temperatures keeps Capital cool; AQI 'satisfactory' at 98

NATION: Pg 5

'Revealing chat with fellow anti-national Soros agents': Rahul attacks govt

FILM: Pg 12

I am never part of the crowd: Sanjay Mishra

India, US chief negotiators to hold four-day trade talks from June 1

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India and the United States will begin a four-day round of trade talks in New Delhi on Monday as negotiators work to finalise the details of an interim trade agreement whose framework was agreed in February.

The US delegation will be led by chief negotiator Brendan Lynch, while India's team will be headed by Darpan Jain, Additional Secretary in the Department of Commerce. According to the Commerce Ministry, discussions will focus on concluding the interim pact and advancing negotiations under the broader Bilateral Trade Agreement (BTA) covering market access, non-tariff measures, customs and trade facilitation, investment promotion, and economic security.

The talks follow changes in the US tariff regime after the US Supreme Court struck down President Donald Trump's reciprocal tariffs in February. **See P10**

NEW GUARD AT THE HELM

General Subramani takes over as CDS, Admiral Swaminathan leads Navy

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Military leadership underwent a significant transition on Sunday with General NS Raja Subramani taking charge as the country's new Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) and Admiral Krishna Swaminathan assuming office as the Chief of the Naval Staff, as the armed forces prepare to address evolving security challenges and pursue major organisational reforms.

General Subramani, widely regarded for his expertise on Pakistan and China, succeeded General Anil Chauhan, who completed his tenure as India's senior-most military commander on Saturday. Shortly after assuming charge, the new CDS outlined his priorities, placing organisational transformation, integration among the three services and military reforms at the centre of his agenda.

"Our armed forces consistently demonstrated professionalism and operational decisiveness in safeguarding our national interests. We are committed to protect the sovereignty and territorial integrity of our country," General Subramani said. He also assured citizens that the armed forces would continue serving the nation with "dedication, courage, honour and professionalism."

A key responsibility before the new CDS will be advancing the government's military theatreisation programme through the establishment of integrated military commands aimed at enhancing coordination among the Army, Navy and Air Force. General Subramani said efforts would also focus on accelerating the development, induction and integration of indigenous weapon systems into the armed forces. **Continued on P4**

BACK FROM BRINK

Vultures stage comeback as captive-breeding, release efforts gather pace

VULTURES MAKE A COMEBACK IN INDIA'S SKIES

Two decades after toxic drugs pushed them to the brink, vultures are returning—thanks to science, safe habitats and stronger protection.

700+ VULTURES bred in captivity

110 VULTURES released into the wild

4 STATES with wild-release programmes

NEW SAFE HAVENS Tiger reserves become ideal release sites

4 JATAYU CONSERVATION BREEDING CENTRES

740 VULTURES currently housed

80 BIRDS rescued

110 VULTURES released into the wild

WHY TIGER RESERVES?

TECHNOLOGY DRIVING SUCCESS

MILESTONES OF RECOVERY

PARTNERS IN CONSERVATION

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

MUMBAI: Two decades after toxic veterinary drugs cleared India's skies of its ultimate scavengers, vultures are making a comeback with more than 700 birds bred in captivity and phased wild-release programmes turning protected tiger reserves into their new safe havens.

Led by the Bombay Natural History Society (BNHS) and state governments, the recovery initiative for the critically endangered white-rumped, long-billed, and slender-billed vulture species has entered a vital new phase with experimental releases across Haryana, West Bengal, Maharashtra, and Assam, BNHS director Kishor Rithe said.

Moreover, monitoring through GPS and GSM transmitters has already shown encouraging survival and dispersal patterns, **Continued on P4**

TWO TITLES, ONE KING

RCB chase 156 in 18 overs after bowlers restrict Titans to 155 for eight in final to win second consecutive IPL title

MPOST BUREAU

AHMEDABAD: Royal Challengers Bengaluru's title defence found its perfect finishing touch in Virat Kohli's bat.

On a night when RCB rarely loosened their grip on the contest, Kohli produced another reminder of his enduring value in a chase, steering his side to a five-wicket victory over Gujarat Titans in the IPL final at the Narendra Modi Stadium on Sunday and securing a second successive championship for the Bengaluru franchise.

Chasing 156 on a sluggish surface, RCB reached 161 for five in 18 overs, with Kohli unbeaten on 75 from 42 deliveries. The winning six, launched off Arshad Khan, not only sealed the match but also unleashed celebrations that had been building throughout a campaign in which Bengaluru looked the team to beat from the outset.

The chase was effectively shaped in the opening exchanges.

Kohli and Venkatesh Iyer came out with attacking intent, refusing to allow Gujarat's bowlers any room to settle. Kagiso Rabada, expected to lead the Titans' challenge, was put under immediate pressure. After Venkatesh punished him in a second over that leaked 18 runs, Kohli joined the assault with a sequence of 4, 4, 6 and 4. The opening pair added 62 runs in just 27 balls, draining belief from a Gujarat side already defending a below-par score. By the end of the Power Play, RCB had surged to 70 for two and appeared firmly on course.

Yet the Titans briefly clawed their way back. Venkatesh fell after his rapid start, Devdutt Padikkal departed soon after, and the wickets of captain Rajat Patidar and Krunal Pandya reduced Bengaluru to 91 for four.

It was the only phase of uncertainty in the chase.

Kohli, as he has done countless times in his career, absorbed the pressure without altering his method. He rotated strike, found timely boundaries and reached his fifth fifty of the season with a pulled four off Arshad Khan. **Continued on P4**

Saket building collapse kills at least six

Eight others injured, FIR registered, 2 MCD engineers suspended

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Six people were killed and eight others injured after a multi-storey commercial building collapsed near Saket Metro Station in south Delhi on Saturday evening, triggering a massive rescue operation that continued for more than 24 hours as authorities searched for possible survivors trapped beneath the debris.

The building, located on Westend Marg in the Saidulajab area, came crashing down, killing at least six people and injuring eight others. Two Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) engineers were suspended. An FIR was registered against five people on the basis of a complaint filed by the victim's family. Three accused were arrested soon after the incident, while Asad remained on the run. **Continued on P4**

Trump says US close to 'very good deal' with Iran, amid reports of changes to pact

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump said Washington and Tehran are nearing a "very good deal" but warned that if the United States does not achieve its objectives, it would "end it a different way."

Speaking in an interview with his daughter-in-law Lara Trump aired on Fox News on Saturday, Trump said Iran was negotiating effectively but claimed the US held "all the cards" after Iran was "militarily defeated."

He said discussions now include a commitment from Iran not to develop or purchase a nuclear weapon. Trump also confirmed a Situation Room meeting on Friday ended without decisions. Axios reported he sought changes to the proposed agreement, including enriched uranium handling and Strait of Hormuz language. Iran is expected to respond within about three days. **See P8**

IMD says heatwave subsided; rain cools down several states

Southwest monsoon likely to advance into parts of Kerala and Tamil Nadu within the next three to four days

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Overcast skies and scattered rainfall brought relief from intense heat across large parts of India on Sunday, with the India Meteorological Department (IMD) saying heatwave conditions have ended across the country. Weather systems linked to an active western disturbance influenced conditions in several northern states, leading to cooler temperatures, thunderstorms and rain, while also causing disruptions in some regions.

In Delhi, temperatures dropped sharply as rain and thunderstorm activity associated with a western disturbance over Rajasthan and central Pakistan affected the region. The national capital recorded a maximum temperature of 35.8 degrees Celsius, which was 4.2 degrees below normal. Most weather stations in the city also reported temperatures below the seasonal average.

The IMD issued a yellow alert for Delhi and forecast generally cloudy skies with light rain or thunderstorms at a few places. The minimum and maximum temperatures on Monday are expected to be around 25 degrees Celsius and 36 degrees Celsius, respectively. **Continued on P4**

Vehicles move on a road amid rainfall, in Noida, Sunday

PM Modi urges people to take precautions amid scorching heat

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday urged people to stay hydrated in view of soaring temperatures across the country.

In his monthly radio broadcast Mann Ki Baat, he said people should take extra precautions when stepping out in the sun. "With temperatures soaring across much of the country, it is important to take extra care. Stay hydrated. If you need to step out in the sun, do so cautiously and take necessary precautions," he said.

"Keep drinking water. Don't forget the guidelines issued by various government departments in this regard either," he said.

Prime Minister Modi had on Wednesday last also urged citizens to take maximum precautions as the country is **Continued on P4**

SEBI

सहकारिता वित्तिय बोर्ड

Securities and Exchange Board of India

NSE

IPFT

PAYMENT TAB KARO

JAB SEBICHECK KARO

SEBI INTRODUCES "VALIDATED UPI HANDLES" TO ENABLE SECURED PAYMENTS

Be Smart.

Scan Now.

Download the Saaṛthi App

#SEBICheck

'NO HEATWAVE LIKELY IN DELHI THIS WEEK'

Drastic drop in temperatures keeps Capital cool; AQI ‘satisfactory’ at 98

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A drastic fall in temperatures kept Delhi cooler than normal on Sunday, with the city recording a maximum temperature of 35.8 degrees Celsius, 4.2 degrees below normal.

The city received 0.9 mm of rainfall in the 24 hours ending 8.30 am on Saturday, while no rainfall was recorded between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm, according to India Meteorological Department (IMD) data.

At Safdarjung, the minimum temperature stood at 23.3 degrees Celsius, 3.6 degrees below normal.

Across other stations, Palam recorded a maximum temperature of 35.5 degrees Celsius, 5.5 degrees below normal, and a minimum of 21.0 degrees Celsius, 6.2 degrees below normal.

Lodhi Road recorded a maximum of 34.7 degrees Celsius, 5.3 degrees below normal, and a minimum of 22.2 degrees Celsius, 3.8 degrees below normal.

The Ridge station logged a maximum temperature of 35.1 degrees Celsius, 4.6 degrees below normal, and a minimum temperature of 21.6 degrees Celsius, 4.5 degrees below normal. Ayanagar recorded a maximum of 34.4 degrees Cel-



“Weather experts attributed the cooler conditions to rain and thunderstorm activity associated with an ongoing western disturbance over Raj and central Pak”

sium, 6.4 degrees below normal, and a minimum of 22.5 degrees Celsius, 3.6 degrees below normal.

Weather experts attributed the cooler conditions to rain and thunderstorm activity associated with an ongoing western disturbance over Rajasthan and central Pakistan.

“The rain and thunderstorm activity over Delhi-NCR is due to the influence of an

Average AQI between Jan-May '26 lowest in eight years barring 2020

NEW DELHI: The average Air Quality Index (AQI) in Delhi between January and May this year stands at 211, the lowest in eight years barring 2020, when pandemic-related curbs sharply brought down AQI levels, the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) said on Sunday.

The commission said the average AQI during this period stood at 214 in 2025, 231 in 2024, 213 in 2023, 238 in 2022, 235 in 2021, 181 in 2020, 237 in 2019, and 243 in 2018.

In a post on X, the CAQM said, “Delhi recorded 75

‘Good to Moderate’ AQI days during January-May of 2026, as against 70 in 2025, 75 in 2024, 74 in 2023, 37 in 2022, 59 in 2021, 98 in 2020, 59 in 2019 and 44 in 2018 respectively, during the corresponding period.”

The commission also highlighted that the average AQI in Delhi during May this year -- recorded at 157 -- has been the lowest during the eight-year period, barring 2020 and 2021.

The average AQI for May stood at 170 in 2025, 223 in 2024, 171 in 2023, 212 in 2022, 144 in 2021 and 2020, 221 in 2019, and 217 in 2018, the CAQM said.

erate”, 201 to 300 “poor”, 301 to 400 “very poor”, and 401 to 500 “severe”.

The IMD has announced a yellow alert with a forecast of generally cloudy skies with light rain or thunderstorms at a few places. The minimum temperature is expected to settle at 25 degrees and the maximum at 36 degrees on Monday.

However, temperatures are expected to gradually rise from

tomorrow as the current spell of rain activity weakens and moves away from the region.

“For the first week of June, no heatwave conditions are likely over Delhi,” Mahesh Palawat of Sky met Weather said.

He said temperatures may rise gradually over the coming days but are expected to remain well below heatwave thresholds during the first week of June.

143 structures face demolition in Shalimar Bagh road project

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Authorities on Sunday began demolishing 143 unauthorised structures in Delhi’s Shalimar Bagh area to remove encroachments from land earmarked for a road-widening project, following directions upheld by the Supreme Court.

The demolition drive was launched in Haiderpur village, where the structures were found within the designated right of way of the proposed Road No. 320 corridor connecting the Shalimar Bagh Railway Under Bridge with the Outer Ring Road.

Backed by a pre-dawn police deployment and extensive security arrangements, the area was turned into a virtual fortress as officials carried out the court-mandated exercise. Senior police officers, including the Deputy Commissioner of Police and Assistant Commissioner of Police, were present at the site to oversee security and maintain law and order.

According to district authorities, the action follows the Supreme Court’s dismissal of a Special Leave Petition challenging the project. The apex court upheld an earlier Delhi High Court ruling that had rejected pleas seeking to halt the demolition and declare decades-old land acquisition proceedings invalid.

District Magistrate S S Parihar said the land forms part of an acquired government parcel designated as a public road



The action follows the SC’s dismissal of a Special Leave Petition challenging the road project

under the Delhi Development Authority’s Master Plan. The project is aimed at easing traffic congestion and improving connectivity between Shalimar Bagh, Azadpur, Ring Road and adjoining residential and commercial areas. Officials said a joint survey conducted by the Delhi Development Authority, Revenue Department, Land and Building Department and Public Works Department in January identified 143 permanent unauthorised structures within the right of way. While the approved corridor width is 30 metres, the current phase targets approximately 10.5 metres of encroached land required for the project.

The administration said the land acquisition process was initiated through notifications issued in 1959 and 1961, with awards announced in 1980. Possession of the land was taken in July 1980 and compensation was deposited by 1981.

Residents had approached the Delhi High Court, arguing that the acquisition had lapsed under provisions of the 2013 land acquisition law. However, the court ruled that the acquisition remained valid and held that the petitioners had failed to establish pre-acquisition ownership rights. A review petition was subsequently dismissed before the matter reached the Supreme Court.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Northwest) Akanksha Yadav said the encroachments on government land were being removed in a phased and systematic manner in compliance with Supreme Court directions and that the demolition drive was progressing as planned.

To ensure the smooth conduct of the operation, Delhi Police personnel were deployed along with 10 companies of Central Armed Police Forces, including the Rapid Action Force, Central Reserve Police Force and Border Security Force. Authorities also undertook drone surveillance, videography and social media monitoring, with all designated sectors placed under close watch.

Police said the demolition drive remained peaceful, with no major law-and-order issues reported. The Delhi government announced Rs 3 lakh ex gratia assistance and temporary accommodation for eligible families, while officials said the exercise would continue until all encroachments are removed.

City Briefs

GANG MEMBER ARRESTED AFTER EXCHANGE OF FIRE WITH POLICE

NEW DELHI: An alleged member of the Himanshu Bhau gang was arrested after a brief exchange of fire with police in outer Delhi’s Mundka area on Saturday night. The accused, identified as 26-year-old Ashish alias Don, was wanted in four criminal cases and had previously been involved in 10 cases, police said. He allegedly opened fire while attempting to evade arrest. A semi-automatic pistol and two empty cartridges were recovered from his possession.

NIGERIAN NATIONAL FOUND DEAD

GREATER NOIDA: A 39-year-old Nigerian national was found dead in an apartment in Greater Noida’s Zeta-1 area, police said on Sunday. The deceased, identified as Mike, was residing in the locality and was reportedly suffering from mental as well as physical ailments. Police were informed about the incident by another Nigerian resident, Charles Kennedy, following which a team from Beta-2 police station reached the spot and initiated an inquiry. According to police, the deceased was known to wander frequently and often slept wherever he happened to be. Prima facie, the death appears to have been caused by illness. An FSL team inspected the scene.

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Economic Offences Wing (EOW) of the Delhi Police has arrested a 58-year-old man from Madhya Pradesh in connection with a Rs 5.20 crore cheque forgery case involving fraudulent withdrawals from a private university’s bank account.

The accused, identified as Sudama Narware, a resident of Betul in Madhya Pradesh, was apprehended from his hometown on Thursday and brought to Delhi for further investigation, police said.

According to investigators, Narware played a key role in a sophisticated financial fraud that targeted a nationalised bank and resulted in the illegal withdrawal of crores of rupees through forged cheques. The case was registered on the complaint of a senior bank official, who reported that unidentified individuals had presented three cheques in August 2019 seek-

ing withdrawal of a total of Rs 6.25 crore. Deputy Commissioner of Police (EOW) Subodh Kumar Goswami said two of the three cheques were successfully cleared, resulting in the transfer of Rs 5.20 crore into two separate bank accounts. One account belonged to a Vadodara-based firm in Gujarat, while the other was linked to a non-governmental organisation (NGO) in Betul. Payment against the third cheque was stopped before it could be processed.

Police investigations revealed that Narware was the secretary and authorised signatory of the NGO that received a portion of the fraudulently withdrawn funds. Further scrutiny of financial transactions showed that he subsequently transferred Rs 2.07 crore from the NGO’s account to the Vadodara-based firm. Investigators also found that Rs 4.16 crore was later routed to Delhi through the bank accounts of five alleged shell companies.

During the probe, investigators discovered that although the original cheque series had been legitimately issued by the bank, the cheques were never delivered to the private university. Fraudsters allegedly exploited this gap by creating forged cheques from the same series and using fabricated signatures to withdraw the funds.

“The cheques were issued but not delivered to the university. Our investigation suggests

that forged cheques carrying fake signatures were used to illegally withdraw the money,” an investigating officer said on condition of anonymity. Police said Narware had been evading arrest since January 2020 and was eventually declared a proclaimed offender by a court. Police officials said three other accused have already been arrested in the case, while at least two more suspects remain absconding.

The investigation is ongoing, and efforts are underway to trace the remaining accused and uncover the full conspiracy behind the multi-crore fraud.

Murder accused linked to Randeep Bhati gang nabbed

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has arrested an alleged associate of the Randeep Bhati gang, who was wanted in a murder case and had been absconding for nearly three years, an officer said on Sunday.

The accused, identified as Anuj Choudhari alias Fighter, was wanted in a murder case registered at Fatehpur Beri police station in south Delhi. A non-bailable warrant had also

been issued against him by a Saket court due to his continued abscondence, he said.

According to police, Choudhari is an active associate of the Randeep Bhati gang, which operates across Delhi-NCR and western Uttar Pradesh.

He was allegedly involved in more than 30 criminal cases, including murder, attempt to murder, criminal conspiracy, Gangster Act, and Arms Act. “A team was working on intel-

ligence inputs regarding the movement of wanted criminals when it received information that Choudhari would arrive in east Delhi carrying illegal weapons. Acting on the tip-off, the team laid a trap near the Paper Market in Ghaziipur and intercepted him,” a senior police officer said.

When police attempted to apprehend him, Choudhari allegedly tried to flee and resisted arrest. He was overpowered after a brief chase and

scuffle.

During the operation, police recovered a semi-automatic pistol, four live cartridges and a stolen scooter from his possession. Verification revealed that the scooter had been stolen from the Laxmi Nagar area in 2025.

The officer said that Choudhari had secured bail in an earlier case in 2023 but subsequently absconded and continued to evade arrest.

DU opens B.Tech admissions

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The University of Delhi (DU) has begun the admission process for its B.Tech programmes for the 2026–27 academic session, with applications open until June 15.

Admissions will be based solely on candidates’ performance in JEE (Main) 2026, with seat allotments prepared using the All India Common Rank List (CRL).

Applicants must meet the university’s eligibility criteria and ensure that details such as their name, date of birth and application information match their JEE Main records.

The counselling fee is Rs 1,500 for UR, OBC-NCL and EWS candidates, and Rs 1,200 for SC, ST and PwBD applicants. Applications must be submitted through DU’s engineering admission portal.

OFFERS IMMEDIATE CARE

LNJP Hosp opens dedicated heat illness ward

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: Amid rising temperature and increasing cases of heat related illness, a dedicated Heat Related Illness Ward has been recently opened at Lok Nayak Jai Prakash (LNJP) Hospital in Delhi as part of the Delhi government’s heatwave preparedness measure.

The initiative has been launched to provide specialised care for patients suffering from heatstroke, dehydration, heat exhaustion and other ailments caused by extreme heat.

According to an official at the ward, around three to

four patients are being admitted each day with symptoms linked to extreme heat. Dr Satyajit Kumar, at LNJP Hospital said, “This ward is specially created for persons suffering from heatstroke. We arrange the required medicine and necessary facilities for the patients so that they receive immediate treatment and proper care.”

Delhi has been experiencing intense heatwave conditions over the past few weeks, with residents—particularly those working outdoors, such as street vendors, drivers and labourers—facing serious health risks due to prolonged exposure to the sun. The



Capital has been experiencing intense heatwave conditions over past few wks

extreme weather has also led to a rise in cases of dehydration,

dizziness, vomiting, weakness and high fever being reported at hospitals across the city.

Recently, Delhi Health Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh reviewed the preparedness measures at LNJP Hospital, including its dedicated heat-related illness ward, supporting ICU facilities and emergency response systems, which have been kept ready to handle any surge in cases. The move comes at a time when several regions across India are on alert due to soaring temperatures. In response, the Delhi government has strengthened healthcare infrastructure and enhanced emergency pre-

paredness across hospitals to protect residents from heat-related illnesses.

With heatwave warnings in place and heat-related health concerns rising across several parts of the country, Delhi’s proactive measures are being seen as an important step towards protecting residents from the growing threat of extreme heat.

Doctors have advised people to stay hydrated, avoid direct exposure to the sun during peak afternoon hours, and seek medical attention promptly if they experience symptoms of heat-related illness.

India’s strength rooted in civilisation: Speaker

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta on Sunday said that India’s strength lies not only in economic growth and technological progress but also in its civilisational consciousness, cultural traditions and moral values.

He made the remarks while releasing the book “Pratham Sindhu Kumbh: Adhyatmik Evam Sanskritik Mahatva” at Shankar Lal Concert Hall, University of Delhi.

Addressing the gathering as chief guest, Gupta said preserving India’s cultural inheritance is essential for nation-building. “India’s



strength lies not only in its economic growth and technological advancement but equally in its civilisational consciousness, cultural traditions and moral foundations,” he said. The programme, organised by the Sindhu Darshan Committee, was attended by spiritual leaders, scholars and members of civil society, including Indresh Kumar and Dr. Dayalu Ji Maharaj.

Describing the event as more than a book release, Gupta said it was an opportunity to reconnect with India’s civilisational heritage and national spirit. He noted that the Sindhu River was not merely a geographical entity but a cornerstone of India’s cultural identity and historical memory.

Gupta said the Sindhu River symbolises India’s civilisational consciousness and cultural continuity. Stressing the need to preserve cultural roots, he said the First Sindhu Kumbh would promote cultural awareness, national integration and engagement with India’s civilisational heritage.

‘EVERYTHING DISAPPEARED’: SURVIVORS RECALL TERRIFYING MOMENTS

SAKET: Study night turns to survival fight

SHRUTI BHARDWAJ

NEW DELHI: One moment, students were eating dinner, revising notes and discussing upcoming exams; the next, they were running for their lives as a deafening roar tore through the evening and a thick cloud of dust engulfed the area.

For the students and office-workers who survived the collapse of a five-storey commercial building near Saket Metro station on Saturday around 7:44 pm, memories remain etched in their minds: Confusion, panic and desperate attempts to escape as the structure crashed down.

Officials said six people died in the incident and several others were rescued and admitted to the hospital. Rescue operations continued through Sunday.

“It felt like the entire area suddenly disappeared,” said Ronit, a medical aspirant who was near the canteen adjoining the building.

“I saw a portion of the building falling and realised that the structure was about to collapse. There was a loud sound, and within seconds everything turned dusty. We could not see who was standing where. People were screaming and running in all directions,” he said. Ronit started calling his friends to leave the library, which is in the building adjacent to the one that collapsed, because he feared the library might also be affected.

The building on Western Marg in the Saidulajab area housed coaching institutes, cafes, offices and a co-working space. Next to the collapsed building stood a small canteen frequented by students preparing for competitive examinations such as Foreign Medical Graduate, NEET and GATE.

Many of these students live in nearby paying guest accommodations and spend long hours studying in libraries and coaching centres before gathering at the canteen for meals and tea breaks.

When the building collapsed, its debris crashed directly onto the tin-shed canteen, trapping several people underneath. Rishab, a regular visitor to the canteen, said there was little warning before disaster struck. “We heard a strange noise, and then suddenly there was chaos. Some people fell while trying to escape, while others were shouting for their friends. My eyes were burning, and people were trying to find a safe place to stand,” he said.

The scenes that followed were equally harrowing.

Students who had escaped returned to the rubble search-

HIGHLIGHTS

» ‘I saw a portion of the building falling and realised that the structure was about to collapse. There was a loud sound, and within seconds everything turned dusty. We could not see who was standing where. People were screaming and running in all directions’

» ‘We heard a strange noise, and then suddenly there was chaos. Some people fell while trying to escape, while others were shouting for their friends. My eyes were burning, and people were trying to find a safe place to stand’

ing for classmates, co-workers and the canteen owner, Parvati Ojha, who later died in the collapse after reportedly going back to warn students. “People were calling names and checking phones to see who was safe,” Rishab said. Among the survivors was Ashutosh.

He initially thought the vibrations were routine. “There is a Metro station nearby, and we often feel slight tremors in the area,” he said. “So when the canteen building started shaking, many of us didn’t think much of it. But within moments it became stronger and then everything collapsed,” he said.

Ashutosh suffered injuries to his leg and shoulder after being struck by falling debris.

“I tried to move away, but some concrete parts fell and hit me, and then I fell and, crawling out, I managed to come out,” he recalled. Other students helped him get to the ambulance, he said. Roma, who worked at a co-working space inside the building, had left to get fresh air outside just five minutes before the building collapsed. “I went out to get fresh air and coffee, and was near the metro. While walking back, I heard a blast-like noise and rushed to see the building collapsed,” she said. Roma said she was lucky to have gone out, but her laptop, bag, and some important documents are still in the debris. Throughout the night, survivors remained near the site. As excavators cleared debris and emergency teams searched for survivors, groups of students stood silently outside the wreckage, replaying the previous evening’s events. PTI



Two MCD engineers suspended

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Two MCD engineers have been suspended with immediate effect in connection with the collapse of a three-storey commercial building near Saket Metro station that left four people dead, officials said on Sunday.

According to an order by the Deputy Commissioner of MCD’s South Zone, Assistant Engineer (Building) Sudesh Singh Chouhan and Junior Engineer (Building) Aman Jain have been placed under suspension over alleged lapses in supervision related to the building that collapsed in the Saidulajab area on Saturday.

The order concerning Chouhan stated that he was suspended for “non-exercising of effective supervision

and slackness on his part” in connection with the collapse of the property, and Jain was suspended for “dereliction of duties and slackness on his part”. The suspensions came a day after the three-storey commercial building near Saket Metro station collapsed, triggering a massive rescue operation involving multiple agencies. The death toll in the incident rose to four on Sunday, while several others were rescued from the debris and shifted to hospital.

The building on Western Marg housed a coaching institute, cafes and offices. Construction work was underway on the upper floor at the time of the collapse.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (South) Anant Mittal said the structure was reduced

to rubble, with debris falling onto an adjoining tin-shed canteen frequented by students preparing for medical entrance examinations.

A multi-agency rescue operation involving the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), Delhi Fire Service (DFS), Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA), Delhi Police and local volunteers continued through the night.

Rescue teams used heavy machinery, hydraulic cutters, victim-location cameras and sniffer dogs to search for those trapped beneath the debris. The operation was later concluded after all trapped persons were accounted for. Authorities have initiated an inquiry, while the exact cause of the collapse is yet to be ascertained.

CM orders magisterial inquiry and survey of unsafe buildings

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In the wake of the tragic building collapse near Saket Metro Station that claimed lives and left several injured, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday rushed to the spot, ordered a magisterial inquiry into the incident, and announced a citywide survey of illegal and dilapidated buildings. Stressing that public safety cannot be compromised, the Chief Minister warned of strict action against both those responsible for the collapse and officials found shielding illegal constructions.

Visiting the collapse site in South Delhi’s Saidulajab area, Gupta reviewed the ongoing rescue and relief operations being carried out jointly by the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), Delhi Fire Services, Delhi Police, district administration, Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA), Civil Defence and other agencies. The Chief Minister directed officials to ensure that rescue operations continue without any negligence and that every possibility of finding trapped persons is explored. She also reviewed the condition of the injured and instructed authorities to provide free and quality treatment to all victims.

Meeting affected families at the site, Gupta expressed con-



CM Rekha Gupta during a visit to the site

PTI

dolences and assured them of government support. Calling the incident deeply distressing, she said, “The Delhi Government stands firmly with the affected families in this difficult time and will provide all possible financial and administrative assistance.” Reiterating that citizen safety remains the government’s top priority, Gupta said, “Negligence at any level will not be tolerated. If any construction-related irregularity, violation of safety norms or administrative lapse is found, strict action will be taken against those responsible.” Acting on the Chief Minister’s directions, a criminal case has been registered at Mehrauli Police Station, while a magisterial inquiry headed by the South Delhi District Magistrate has been ordered to determine the exact cause of the collapse and fix accountability.

The Chief Minister further instructed departments concerned to immediately survey and inspect dangerous, dilapidated and illegal buildings in Saidulajab and adjoining areas. “Strict action should be taken in accordance with the law against buildings that pose a threat to public safety so that such incidents can be prevented in future,” she said.

Issuing a stern warning to officials, Gupta added that accountability would be fixed on those who failed to perform their duties or protected illegal constructions. “Any official found guilty will also face strict action,” she said. The Chief Minister said the government would closely monitor relief, rehabilitation and investigation efforts and intensify its drive against illegal and unsafe constructions across the national capital.

City Briefs

SPORTS SHAPE CHARACTER, LEADERSHIP AND TEAMWORK, SAYS MAYOR WAHI

NEW DELHI: Delhi Mayor Pravesh Wahi on Sunday highlighted the importance of sports in shaping the character and personality of young people while attending the closing ceremony of the 51st Goswami Ganesh Dutt Cricket Tournament. Speaking as the chief guest at the event held at Khalsa College, Wahi said that sports contribute significantly to the development of discipline, dedication, leadership skills and team spirit among youth. He noted that sporting activities not only promote physical fitness but also instil values essential for personal and professional growth. Emphasising the popularity of cricket in India, the Mayor said tournaments at the grassroots level provide aspiring players with a platform to showcase their talent and pursue excellence in the sport. He congratulated all participating teams for their competitive spirit and sportsmanship. Former Test cricketer Ajay Sharma was also present at the ceremony. Wahi lauded his contribution to Indian cricket and said experienced sportspersons play a crucial role in motivating the next generation of athletes. The Mayor extended congratulations to the winner and runner-up teams, with special praise for Sehgal Cricket Club for its performance during the tournament. He also appreciated the efforts of the organisers for successfully conducting the event and reiterated the Municipal Corporation of Delhi’s commitment to strengthening sports infrastructure and encouraging youth participation in line with the Centre’s Khelo India initiative.

GGM ROAD RAGE: BMW OWNER BOOKED

GURUGRAM: A man was booked for allegedly hitting a businessman’s car with his car and threatening to kill him following a road rage incident in Gurugram’s DLF Phase 1, officials said on Sunday. A case was registered at Sector 53 police station based on a complaint filed by Yatin Ghai, a resident of DLF Phase 1. According to the complaint, the incident occurred around 7.30 am on May 30 when Ghai arrived near the barrier of The Palms Springs Society in his car. He alleged that another businessman, identified as Rohan Gupta, who arrived in a BMW, approached him, abused him and issued threats. The complainant further alleged that Gupta deliberately rammed his vehicle, causing damage.

‘MANN KI BAAT’ OUTREACH



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta participates in the collective listening of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s ‘Mann Ki Baat’ during the ‘Viksit Malviya Nagar Sankalp Samaroh’ at NCUI Auditorium, Sri Aurobindo Marg, on Sunday. The CM also distributed bicycles to meritorious and economically underprivileged girl students and installed water pots for birds, promoting education, women’s empowerment and environmental awareness

‘UNMET NEED RISES’

Use of family planning methods declines in Capital: NFHS-6

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The use of family planning methods among currently married women aged 15-49 declined in Delhi between 2019-21 and 2023-24, while the unmet need for family planning increased, according to data from the latest National Family Health Survey.

According to the NFHS-6, 67.4 per cent of currently married women aged 15-49 years were using ‘any family’ plan-

ning method — both modern and traditional methods — in 2023-24, down from 76.4 per cent in 2019-21 (NFHS-5).

The use of any modern method declined to 51.2 per cent from 57.7 per cent, while traditional ones fell to 16.2 per cent from 18.7 per cent.

The survey said “any modern method” includes modern family planning methods, including those not shown separately in the fact sheet.

Among specific methods,

in Delhi, female sterilisation declined to 14.7 per cent from 18 per cent, while male sterilisation increased marginally to 0.4 per cent from 0.2 per cent.

The survey also recorded an increase in the unmet need for family planning. The total unmet need for family planning increased to 7.3 per cent in 2023-24 from 6.1 per cent in 2019-21.

According to the survey, unmet need for family planning refers to fecund women --

the biological and physiological capacity to produce offspring — who are not using contraception but wish to postpone their next birth, referred to as spacing, or stop childbearing altogether, referred to as limiting.

The survey said women are considered to have an unmet need for spacing if they are at risk of becoming pregnant, not using contraception, and either do not want to get pregnant within the next two years or are unsure if or when they

want to become pregnant. It also includes women who are pregnant with a mistimed pregnancy. The survey further includes women who are postpartum amenorrhoeic (have not resumed menstruation after childbirth) for up to two years following a mistimed birth and are not using contraception.

Unmet need for spacing increased to 2.7 per cent from 2.0 per cent.

According to the survey, women are considered to have

an unmet need for limiting if they are at risk of becoming pregnant, are not using contraception and do not want any more children. It also includes women who are pregnant with an unwanted pregnancy.

The survey further includes women who are postpartum amenorrhoeic (have not resumed menstruation after childbirth) for up to two years following an unwanted birth and are not using contraception.

Unmet need for limiting

increased to 4.6 per cent from 4.1 per cent.

The data also showed that the proportion married before the age of 21 declined to 8.1 per cent from 12 per cent.

Delhi’s total fertility rate remained unchanged at 1.6 children per woman in both survey rounds. The proportion

of women aged 15-19 years who were already mothers or pregnant at the time of the survey declined to 2.4 per cent from 3.3 per cent. The survey also recorded improvements in education indicators.

The proportion of women with 10 or more years of schooling increased to 64 per cent from 59.7 per cent, while the proportion of men with 10 or more years of schooling rose to 67.6 per cent from 60.9 per cent. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

LUCKNOW BENCH OF ALLAHABAD HC DELIVERS SIGNIFICANT RULING

Lok Adalats, DLSAs have no authority to grant divorce, says Allahabad HC

OUR CORRESPONDENT

LUCKNOW: In a significant ruling, the Lucknow Bench of the Allahabad High Court recently held that Lok Adalats and district legal services authorities have no jurisdiction to grant divorce decrees.

The court, in an order passed on April 30, said the power to dissolve a marriage rests exclusively with family courts, while the authority of Lok Adalats is limited to facilitating settlements between parties, and it cannot render judicial decisions.

A division bench comprising Justice Shekhar B Saraf and Justice A K Chaudhary passed the verdict on a petition by a woman challenging an order by District Legal Services Authority (DLSA), Unnao in 2018.

Her husband, she alleged, had treated the settlement



Allahabad High Court

recorded by the DLSA as a decree of divorce and relied on it as the basis for remarriage.

The court observed that under the Legal Services Authorities Act, 1987, and the National Legal Services Authority (Lok Adalat) Regulations, 2009, matrimonial disputes involving divorce cannot be referred to Lok

Adalats for adjudication.

It emphasised that the role of a Lok Adalat is confined to promoting amicable settlement between parties and not to deciding disputes judicially.

Expressing concern over the proceedings conducted by DLSA, Unnao, the bench noted that when the law itself prohibits Lok Adalats from

Highlights

» The court, in an order passed on April 30, said the power to dissolve a marriage rests exclusively with family courts

» A division bench comprising Justice Shekhar B Saraf and Justice A K Chaudhary passed the verdict on a petition by a woman challenging an order by District Legal Services Authority (DLSA), Unnao in 2018

granting divorce, passing such orders amounts to an overreach of jurisdiction.

The court held that a clause in the settlement stating that both parties were free to remarry was legally untenable and void.

The bench clarified that

no valid decree of divorce had ever been passed by a competent court in the matter. Therefore, the husband's reliance on the settlement as proof of divorce could not be recognised in law.

While disposing of the petition, the high court granted the petitioner liberty to pursue appropriate remedies in accordance with law.

It also directed that a copy of the judgment be circulated to all Lok Adalats and district legal services authorities across the state for future guidance and compliance.

The court observed that Lok Adalats are an important mechanism for ensuring speedy and accessible justice, but they must operate within the limits of their statutory authority and refrain from encroaching upon areas reserved for regular courts.

NSA Ajit Doval meets Myanmar President Aung Hlaing in Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: National Security Advisor Ajit Doval on Sunday met Myanmar's President U Min Aung Hlaing and discussed key issues relating to bilateral ties.

Aung Hlaing, who is on a five-day trip to India, is scheduled to hold wide-ranging talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday, focusing on ramping up ties in trade, connectivity, border security and defence.

"NSA Shri Ajit Doval called on President U Min Aung Hlaing of Myanmar today," External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said on X.

Aung Hlaing's visit to India comes less than two months after he became the president following Myanmar's parliamentary elections.

The elections were held in December and January, after years of protests against the ruling military-junta that seized power in a coup on February 1, 2021, overthrowing the democratically elected government of Aung San Suu Kyi.



National Security Advisor (NSA) Ajit Doval during a meeting with the Myanmar President U Min Aung Hlaing, in New Delhi

Myanmar is one of India's strategic neighbours and shares a 1,640-kilometre-long border with a number of northeastern states, including militancy-hit Nagaland and Manipur.

The Myanmar leader is accompanied by a high-level delegation comprising several cabinet ministers, senior officials and business leaders.

Aung Hlaing was earlier scheduled to visit New Delhi to participate in the Interna-

tional Big Cat Alliance Summit on June 1, which has been deferred.

The Myanmar president will also travel to Mumbai on June 2 for business and industry interactions and site visits.

At his weekly media briefing on Friday, Jaiswal had said that issues relating to border security and connectivity, among others, would be discussed during the Myanmar leader's trip to India.

From Page 1

IMD

Meteorologists said temperatures are likely to rise gradually from Monday as the current spell of rain weakens and moves away from the region.

The weather department also forecast moderate to severe thunderstorm activity over northwest, central and adjoining eastern India, with squally winds reaching up to 90 km/h. It further said the southwest monsoon could advance into parts of Kerala and Tamil Nadu over the next three to four days.

In Uttarakhand, heavy rainfall and adverse weather conditions disrupted normal life and affected the Kedarnath Yatra. Authorities temporarily suspended the pilgrimage after rain-related concerns left hundreds of pilgrims stranded. The restrictions were lifted later after rainfall subsided and conditions improved.

A major accident was also averted in Champawat district, where more than 50 pilgrims trapped in a swollen river near the Sri Reetha Sahib Gurdwara during the annual Jod Mela were rescued by authorities, officials said.

Temperatures across Uttarakhand remained well below normal levels over the weekend. In Dehradun, the maximum temperature settled at 26.6 degrees Celsius and the minimum at 17 degrees Celsius, nine degrees and five degrees below normal, respectively. The IMD said high-altitude areas above 3,800 metres could receive snowfall and issued a yellow watch warning for thunderstorms, lightning, gusty winds of 40 to 50 kmph and intense rainfall.

Rajasthan witnessed dust storm conditions for the second consecutive day. In Jaisalmer district, a large dust cloud moved towards populated areas, reducing visibility and strengthening wind conditions. No casualties or damage were reported. Some parts of the state also received light to moderate rainfall. Phalodi recorded the highest maximum temperature at 42.6 degrees Celsius, while Sirohi registered the lowest minimum temperature at 18.2 degrees Celsius.

In Himachal Pradesh, light to moderate rain was reported in several areas over the past two days. Naina Devi received the highest rainfall at 46.4 mm. Thunderstorms accompanied by lightning were recorded in Shimla, Juberhatti, Sundernagar, Kangra, Jot and Murari Devi. Kukumseri was the coldest place in the state with a minimum temperature of 3.8 degrees Celsius, while Una recorded the highest maximum temperature at 33.4 degrees Celsius.

A day after widespread rain in Haryana and Punjab, temperatures remained significantly below normal. Chandigarh recorded a maximum temperature of 32 degrees Celsius, more than seven degrees below the seasonal average.

In Uttar Pradesh, Lucknow received 2.4 mm of rainfall and recorded a maximum temperature of 36.3 degrees Celsius, 3.9 degrees below normal. The minimum temperature was 24.7 degrees Celsius. Ballia recorded 34.4 mm of rainfall, while Moradabad received 21.8 mm. The meteorological depart-

ment warned of thunderstorms, lightning and gusty winds at isolated places across western and eastern parts of the state.

Meanwhile, Jammu and Kashmir largely experienced normal weather. Srinagar recorded a maximum temperature of 28.4 degrees Celsius, about 2.4 degrees above normal. The IMD has forecast isolated showers across parts of the Union Territory over the next 72 hours, with fairly widespread rainfall expected on June 4.

PM Modi

F convoy that left two personnel dead and two others injured. "It was a painful terror incident. Srinagar and Bandipora police worked whole night and arrested two OGWs involved in the attack,"

Lawaypora

witnessing soaring temperatures, and said staying hydrated is key during such harsh weather.

Modi also referred to the king of fruits, saying there is hardly a home where mangoes are not talked about in the summer season. He noted that every region has its own mango and its own aroma.

"Hapus or alphonso of Maharashtra, Kesar of Gujarat - these are the lifeblood of 'aamras'; Dussehri of Uttar Pradesh and Langra of Kashi. There are mangoes from Bihar, whose aroma can be smelt from far. Chausa, Malda - memories of people are tied to every name," he said.

The prime minister said if someone goes to South India, people will find other varieties like Banganapalli, Totapuri, Neelam, Malgova; there is Himsagar in Bengal; Suvarnarekha of Odisha and Andhra Pradesh. "In other words, the place changes, and so does the mango's form, colour, and taste... This journey of the mango is now reaching from villages to the global market," he said.

Saket building

down around 7.40 pm. Police said the structure housed a coaching institute, cafes and offices, while construction work was reportedly underway on its upper floor at the time of the collapse.

The area is a well-known hub for students preparing for competitive examinations, particularly those seeking admission to medical and engineering courses abroad. Police sources said many of the victims were aspirants preparing for examinations, including the Foreign Medical Graduate Examination (FMGE).

Officials said five of the injured succumbed to their injuries at AIIMS, while another person died at Safdarjung Hospital, taking the death toll to six. Five injured persons remain under treatment at AIIMS, while three others have been discharged.

The deceased were identified as Ravi (24), Kapil (28), Nalin Ray (23), Alok, Parvati (35) and Ekta (24).

The injured were identified as Kshitij Pratap (25), Neelam Yadav (25), Anuj Dixit (22), Tarun (25), Saika Khan (27), Aastha (26), Aditya Sharma (24) and Vishal (25). Officials said all were initially

shifted to the AIIMS Trauma Centre. Among the injured are two medical graduates, two GATE aspirants and an engineer.

According to the District Disaster Management Authority (DDMA), an emergency call was received at the Emergency Operation Centre at 7.40 pm. A Quick Response Vehicle was immediately dispatched and rescue operations were launched.

When rescue teams reached the site, they found that the building, spread over approximately 300 to 400 square yards, had completely collapsed. Local residents informed authorities that around 10 to 15 people were feared trapped under the rubble.

Search and rescue operations involving the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), Delhi Fire Services, DDMA, Delhi Police, Delhi Civil Defence and other emergency agencies continued through Sunday. Heavy machinery, including Hydras, JCBs and Rotavators, was deployed to clear debris and locate anyone still trapped.

Officials said a large section of the collapsed structure fell onto an adjoining tin-shed canteen frequented by students. The canteen was owned by Parvati Ojha, a Nepal-born woman in her early 50s. Eyewitnesses described scenes of panic moments before the collapse. Videos circulating on social media showed a student recording after noticing stones and bricks falling onto the road. Seconds later, the entire structure collapsed, sending a huge cloud of dust into the air.

"One moment, students were eating dinner, revising notes and discussing upcoming exams; the next, they were running for their lives as a deafening roar tore through the evening and a thick cloud of dust engulfed the area," an eyewitness said.

Among those killed was Kapil, who was preparing for recruitment at the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre (BARC). Friends said he and five others had gathered at the canteen after he performed well in an interview. The results are expected in July.

Nalin Ray, a resident of Bihar's Nawada district, had recently completed his BTech degree and was preparing for the Graduate Aptitude Test in Engineering (GATE). Family members said he had spoken to them earlier on Saturday and was planning to return home during his upcoming break.

Another victim, Ekta, a Bachelor of Dental Surgery graduate from Rajasthan's Alwar district, had been living in Delhi for the past year while preparing for the FMGE scheduled on June 28. Her father, Ramesh Chand, said she had appeared for a test on Saturday morning and was pleased with her performance.

"Her exam had gone well, and she was very happy. She spoke to family members twice in the afternoon, and everyone at home was celebrating her performance," Chand said.

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta visited the site on Sunday and assured strict action against unauthorised constructions and officials found responsible. An FIR has been registered at Mehrauli police station under relevant sections, including culpable homicide.

Authorities have formed investigation teams to examine the circumstances leading to the collapse and to arrest the building owner. The inquiry will be conducted

under the supervision of the South District Magistrate on the chief minister's directions.

In administrative action following the incident, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi suspended Assistant Engineer (Building) Sudesh Singh Chouhan and Junior Engineer (Building) Aman Jain over alleged lapses in supervision.

Officials said a detailed inquiry would determine whether structural weaknesses, ongoing construction activity or violations of building regulations contributed to the tragedy. Further legal action will be taken based on the findings.

CDS

Before his appointment, General Subramani served as Military Advisor at the National Security Council Secretariat. He retired as Vice Chief of Army Staff on July 31, 2025, after holding the post for over a year. Earlier, he led the Army's Central Command as General Officer Commanding-in-Chief from March 2023 to June 2024.

Commissioned into the 8th Battalion of the Garhwal Rifles on December 14, 1985, General Subramani has served for more than four decades across a variety of operational environments. His command assignments include leading 16 Garhwal Rifles during counter-insurgency operations in Assam under Operation Rhino, commanding the 168 Infantry Brigade in Jammu and Kashmir, and heading the 17 Mountain Division in the Central Sector. He also commanded two corps, including one of the Army's premier strike corps on the western front. His staff and instructional appointments included serving as Defence Attaché in Kazakhstan, Deputy Director General of Military Intelligence, Chief Instructor (Army) at the Defence Services Staff College in Wellington, and Chief of Staff at Headquarters Northern Command. He is a graduate of the National Defence Academy and the Indian Military Academy, and has pursued higher studies at the Joint Services Command and Staff College in the United Kingdom, the National Defence College in New Delhi, King's College London, and Madras University. For his service, he has been awarded the Param Vishisht Seva Medal, Ati Vishisht Seva Medal, Sena Medal and Vishisht Seva Medal.

In a parallel change of command, Admiral Krishna Swaminathan assumed office as the Chief of the Naval Staff, succeeding Admiral Dinesh Kumar Tripathi, who retired from the service. Taking charge at a time of heightened maritime challenges, Admiral Swaminathan said the Indian Navy remains actively deployed in a security environment that is "challenging, complex, unpredictable, and uncertain."

"The Indian Navy stands vigilant to protect national interests wherever they are," he said, adding that maintaining the highest standards of operational readiness and combat effectiveness would be his foremost priority to safeguard India's security and economic interests.

Prior to becoming Navy chief, Admiral Swaminathan served as the Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief of the Western Naval Command. He noted that the Navy is already on a path of capability enhancement and modernisation and pledged to sustain that

momentum.

"It shall be my endeavour to sustain the growth momentum of the Navy, consolidate all ongoing programmes, scale up where required, and sharpen our operational capabilities through the induction of niche and emerging technologies," he said.

The appointments place two experienced military leaders at the helm of India's defence establishment as the armed forces pursue modernisation, indigenous capability development and greater integration across services while responding to emerging security challenges on land and at sea.

Encounter

Deputy Commissioner of Police (City/Trans-Hindon) Dhawal Jaiswal said police received information that Asad was planning to meet associates in the area and arrange money before fleeing. Security checks and combing operations were already underway when police spotted him riding a motorcycle with an accomplice in the Vasundhara-Khoda area.

"When officers tried to stop them, Asad opened fire on the police team," Jaiswal said. Police retaliated, injuring Asad, who was taken to a hospital and later declared dead. A pistol and cartridges were recovered from him, police said. The accomplice escaped and efforts are continuing to trace him.

Investigators said Surya and the accused knew each other. Police said preliminary findings indicate a dispute over motorcycle riding escalated into a fatal attack. They also said Surya had been called to meet the accused on Eid-ul-Adha. Sources involved in the investigation said the victim was allegedly lured to the location under the pretext of Eid greetings and seeing a sacrificial animal. The victim's family, however, has alleged that he was called to a meeting spot and attacked by several people armed with knives.

Police have arrested Nawab, Asad's father, along with associates Atif and Farhan. Two other persons are being questioned.

The killing of the teenager led to tension in the area, with members of several Hindu organisations gathering at the victim's residence. The family initially refused to perform the last rites and demanded strict action against all those involved. Following discussions with officials and assurances of security, financial assistance, a fire-arms licence and other support, the cremation was carried out.

The Uttar Pradesh government has announced Rs 5 lakh compensation and a government job for one member of the victim's family. Deputy Chief Minister Keshav Prasad Maurya said the killers would face the strictest punishment under the law, while BSP chief Mayawati described the incident as "extremely tragic and worrying" and sought stringent action against those responsible.

Vultures

with a long-billed vulture released from Pench travelling 750 km to Nashik, Maharashtra, in 17 days.

Rithe, however, noted that long-term success would depend on the availability of safe food

sources beyond protected areas, such as sanctuaries, national parks and conservation reserves.

"The breeding and release programme can succeed only when a safe environment is created for vultures beyond protected areas. Eliminating harmful NSAIDs and ensuring safe food sources remain critical for the recovery of these species," he said.

The BNHS first documented the sharp decline in vulture populations across the Indian subcontinent in 1999, and subsequent research established that diclofenac, a veterinary non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drug (NSAID), was responsible for mass mortality among the birds.

This finding prompted a ban on the drug in 2006, followed by subsequent prohibitions on other toxic variants like ketoprofen, aceclofenac, and nimesulide, Rithe said.

To prevent total extinction, the BNHS and state forest departments, with the support of the Royal Society for the Protection of Birds (RSPB), established four Jatayu Conservation Breeding Centres at Pinjore (Haryana), Rajahmundry (West Bengal), Rani (Assam), and Bhopal (Madhya Pradesh).

These facilities currently house 740 vultures. The programme has supplied 80 birds and released 110 vultures into the wild as part of reintroduction efforts.

The reintroduction efforts have already shown remarkable milestones, such as captive-bred white-rumped vultures released in Haryana in 2020 have begun breeding naturally in the wild. Meanwhile, 31 birds released from West Bengal have dispersed safely across India, Nepal, and Bhutan with zero reported NSAID-linked mortalities.

Maharashtra has emerged as a major centre for vulture reintroduction, with releases taking place in Pench, Tadoba-Andhari and Melghat Tiger Reserves.

Recent conservation focus has shifted heavily toward secure tiger reserves, such as Pench, Tadoba-Andhari, and Melghat, where large landscapes offer abundant natural carrion free from domestic cattle drugs.

As many as 20 vultures were transferred to Maharashtra from Haryana in 2024 and another 34 birds in 2025 for phased release programmes, while Assam initiated its first soft-release of slender-billed vultures in the Kaziranga landscape this March.

Conservationists said tiger reserves have become ideal release sites because large protected landscapes are largely free from harmful veterinary drugs and provide abundant natural food sources and wild carrion of deer species like chital and sambar.

Citizen-science surveys cited by BNHS have recorded increasing vulture population trends in several protected areas and tiger reserves, indicating that conservation measures and improved habitat protection are beginning to reverse decades of decline.

The programme is being implemented with support from the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, the Central Zoo Authority, state forest departments and several national and international conservation organisations.

Two Titles

Tim David then supplied the finishing acceleration. His 24 off 17 balls ensured the asking rate never rose to troubling levels and allowed Kohli to dictate the chase.

The former India captain enjoyed a slice of fortune when Shubman Gill appeared to have completed a catch off Arshad, only for television replays to show the ball had touched the turf before being secured. Gujarat's hopes faded further thereafter.

Appropriately, it was Kohli who completed the job. His towering six off Arshad ended the contest and transformed the RCB dugout into a scene of celebration. Patidar, usually reserved in demeanour, broke into a broad smile as teammates sprinted onto the field to embrace the man who has remained the franchise's central figure since 2008.

Earlier, Bengaluru's bowlers had done the hard work by exploiting a slow pitch with impressive discipline.

The mixed red-and-black soil surface on pitch No. 6 offered little assistance to stroke-makers and RCB's attack repeatedly hit the right lengths to keep Gujarat under control.

Washington Sundar fought a lone battle with an unbeaten 50 from 37 balls, striking five fours, but the innings never gathered momentum around him.

For Gujarat, much depended on opening pair Shubman Gill and Sai Sudharsan, both of whom had crossed the 700-run mark this season. Neither could provide the start their side required.

Gill's attempt to attack Josh Hazlewood ended with a leading edge that floated to Patidar. Sudharsan survived an earlier caught-behind appeal after a successful review but did not last much longer. Bhuvneshwar Kumar forced a miscued pull with a well-directed short ball and wicketkeeper Jitesh Sharma completed the catch.

At 45 for two in the Power Play, Gujarat were already struggling to build a platform.

Jos Buttler made 19 and attempted to rebuild alongside Washington, but boundaries were difficult to come by and neither batter managed to change gears. Gujarat's first six did not arrive until the 13th over when Arshad Khan dragged Krunal Pandya over midwicket, a statistic that summed up the innings.

The impressive Rasikh Salam Dhar further tightened RCB's hold on the game. Continuing a breakthrough season, the young pacer returned figures of three for 27 and removed Nishant Sindhu, who scored 20 off 18 balls, and Rahul Tewatia before Gujarat could mount a late charge.

Bhuvneshwar finished with two for 29 while Hazlewood claimed two for 37 as RCB restricted the Titans to 155 for eight.

Washington's unbeaten half-century ensured Gujarat crossed 150, but the total always looked vulnerable on a night when Bengaluru appeared sharper in every department. Any lingering effects of Gujarat's demanding schedule, which included Friday's Qualifier 2 and weather-related travel delays from Mullanpur, mattered little against an RCB side that executed its plans with precision.

From the discipline of the bowlers to the authority of Kohli's unbeaten 75, the final belonged to Bengaluru. When the decisive blow arrived, it merely confirmed what much of the evening had suggested: RCB were champions again.

INDIAN SIDE WILL BE LED BY BSF DG PRAVEEN KUMAR

India-B’desh border talks in Delhi next week; 1st after new BNP govt

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India and Bangladesh are expected to hold their bi-annual DG-level border talks in Delhi next week, the first such meeting after the BNP government took charge in Dhaka early this year.

Issues related to border fencing, attacks on BSF personnel, checking infiltration and cross-border crimes and handing over of illegal Bangladeshi migrants are likely to be part of the agenda for the talks, sources said.

A delegation of the Border Guard Bangladesh (BGB) led by its Director General (DG) Maj Gen Mohammad Ashrafuzzaman Siddiqui is expected to be in the national capital between June 8 and 11 for the talks with their counterpart Border Security Force (BSF).

The Indian side will be led by BSF DG Praveen Kumar. India shares a 4,096 km-

Highlights

» BSF-BGB DG-level talks are to be held between June 8-11 at a BSF base in Delhi, said officials

» The last meeting between the two sides was held in Dhaka in August 2025

» India shares a 4,096 km-long international border with Bangladesh

long international border with Bangladesh, out of which about 860 km remains unfenced, including 174.51 km of the “not feasible for fencing” gap.

Officials told the news agency that the BSF-BGB DG-level talks are to be held between June 8-11 at a BSF base in Delhi.

They said that issues related to cross-border crimes and mutual cooperation are expected to be the crux of discussions, as the agenda of talks between the two countries, by and large, remains the same.

A joint record of discussions will be signed between the two sides on June 11, they said.

Sources in the security establishment noted that this will be the first top-level border meeting between the two forces after the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) was elected to power in February this year.

The last meeting between the two sides was held in Dhaka in August 2025, when an interim government headed by Muhammad Yunus was in power in Bangladesh.

The forthcoming meeting assumes significance as the Modi government, through the public speeches of Union Home minister Amit Shah, has underlined that India will not allow illegal infiltration of Bangladeshis and Rohingyas.

The government asserted that all such people who were present in the country will face a graded 3D action of ‘detect, delete and deport’.

More than half of the over 4,000 km India-Bangladesh border is shared by the state of West Bengal (2,216.7 km) where a new BJP government led by Chief Minister Suvenud Adhikari has taken charge recently.

Adhikari too has reiterated the Union government’s 3D approach against illegal infiltrators present in the state, even as his government has handed over large tracts of land to the BSF for the erection of a strong fence.

According to government data of August 2025, a total of 1,647.69 km of the 2,216 km border in West Bengal has been fenced and out of this, 112.78 km cannot be fenced as it is non-feasible due to geographical features like water bodies

and the Sunderbans mangrove area. A total of 456.22 km is feasible for fencing works.

Four other states share a border with Bangladesh -- Tripura (856 km), Meghalaya (443 km), Assam (262 km) and Mizoram (318 km).

The sources said the BSF agenda points for the forthcoming talks may include prevention against attack, assault, abuse and stone pelting on BSF personnel and Indian nationals by Bangladesh-based criminals/miscreants, joint efforts to prevent trans-border crimes, action against Indian Insurgent Groups (IIGs) in Bangladesh and denial and delay in taking over apprehended illegal Bangladeshi entrants by the BGB.

Issues related to border infrastructure, construction of a single-row fence (SRF), and air violations (including drone intrusions) may also be part of the talks from the Indian side, the sources said.

RAHUL ATTACKS GOVT OVER CBSE OSM ROW

‘Revealing chat with fellow anti-national Soros agents’

OUR CORRESPONDENT



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi during an interaction with CBSE board students PTI

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday targeted the Centre over the CBSE OSM row, sharing a video of his interaction with a group of students and describing them as brave young Indians who asked the Modi government simple questions but received “insults instead of answers”.

Asserting that the students deserved a bright future, Gandhi said, “We will make sure they get it”.

Posting the clip on his social media accounts, Gandhi described it as a “revealing chat with my fellow ‘anti-national Soros agents.”

“Vedant and his friends are brilliant, brave young Indians who asked CBSE and the Modi government simple questions -- but got insults instead of answers,” Gandhi said in his post on X, accompanying the video.

“They deserve a bright and secure future. We will make sure they get it,” he added.

Vedant, a Class 12 student, had recently alleged in a post on X that the Physics answer sheet uploaded by the CBSE under the revaluation process was not his. It went viral, after which several other students took to social media with similar claims.

In the video, Gandhi is seen having an informal chat with Vedant and other students about their ordeal. He also joked about how they were labelled “Pakistanis” and “deep state agents” after raising what he called legit-

imate concerns and issues.

“You are students. You are asking for your answer sheets, that’s all. Now, suddenly, you have become anti-nationals. You have to accept the problem if you have to solve the problem. You are refusing to accept the problem and blaming the poor kids and saying ‘you are deep state, you are spies, terrorists,” Gandhi says in the video, attacking the government over the On-Screen Marking (OSM) controversy.

‘No proposal yet on K’taka Cabinet under CM-designate Shivakumar’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KALABURAGI: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Sunday said no proposal had yet been received regarding the composition of the new Karnataka ministers under Chief Minister-designate D K Shivakumar.

He also indicated that decisions on ministers, deputy chief ministers and key appointments would be taken only after consultations following the June 3 swearing-in ceremony.

Addressing reporters here, Kharge said discussions were underway on various aspects of the govern-

ment formation process, but no formal proposal had been placed before the party leadership so far.

“We will have to see. No proposal has come yet (on the appointment of ministers). Once the proposal comes, discussions will be held on how many ministers and deputy chief ministers should be appointed, on

whether important chairmanships should also be filled along with it,” he said.

Kharge said the party would get clarity only after the swearing-in ceremony. “All these matters are under discussion. We will know after June 3. Right now, we have to wait,” he said.

Referring to the possibility of expanding the cabinet in phases, he said, “Whether he (CM-designate) will appoint eight or ten ministers, we have not received their proposal. Once it comes, one phase may be completed first, and then after 15 days or a month, another phase may be taken up for the remaining (posts).”

CM Vijay to visit Tiruchirappalli on Jun 1 to thank voters

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay will visit Tiruchirappalli on June 1 to thank the voters of Tiruchirappalli East Assembly constituency from where he won and subsequently resigned his seat, party sources said on Sunday.

TVK president Vijay had successfully contested from both Tiruchirappalli East and Perambur (Chennai) Assembly constituencies in the recently held Assembly elections.

MP0ST

ASHWANI SHARMA

SHIMLA: The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) scored a decisive political victory in local urban body elections, the results of which were declared on Sunday.

The results are being viewed as an important political indicator ahead of the 2027 Assembly elections.

The party has won three of the four municipal corporations that went to the polls, causing a blow to the incumbent Congress government in the state, which will witness Assembly polls in 2027.

The BJP has secured control of the municipal corporations in Mandi, Dharamshala, and Solan,



while the Congress managed to retain only Palampur because of the influence of sitting Congress MLA Ashish Butail, who happens to be the son of former Speaker and veteran Congress leader BBL Butail.

The Congress has won 11 of

15 municipal wards in Palampur, the tea town of Himachal Pradesh, while the BJP managed to win four seats.

Palampur also happens to be the native town of BJP stalwart and former Chief Minister Shanta Kumar, who, despite

having taken retirement from politics, had issued an appeal in favour of the BJP

In Mandi, the BJP registered a landslide victory by winning 12 of the 14 wards, retaining the civic body for a second consecutive term. Mandi happens to be a stronghold of Pt Sukh Ram, a former union minister whose son Anil Sharma is the local MLA and has served as a cabinet minister, both in the Congress and the BJP governments.

It is, however, former Chief Minister Jairam Thakur who stole the limelight in the party’s victory, as he happens to be the leader of the Opposition in the state and also a dominant leader in Mandi.

Operation Toofan: Kerala to roll out major anti-drug drive on June 2

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The Kerala government will launch “Operation Toofan: The Narco Hunt”, billed as one of the largest anti-drug campaigns in South India, on June 2 as part of a comprehensive crackdown on narcotics networks operating in the state.

The initiative, announced by state home minister Ramesh Chennithala shortly after assuming office, aims to curb the spread of narcotics through stringent law enforcement measures and a broad-based public awareness campaign, according to an official statement issued on Sunday.

The Kerala Police, in coordination with various government departments, will spearhead the operation, focusing on dismantling drug trafficking networks and building a strong community-led resistance against substance abuse.

The project has been designed to address the rapid spread of synthetic drugs, using technology-driven surveillance and modern investigative techniques. Authorities said cooperation with police and home departments across South India would be strengthened to tackle interstate drug syndicates.

As part of the initiative, a digitally enabled system will be established to facilitate the swift reporting of drug-related activities. Mobile applications and WhatsApp chatbots will be introduced to allow citizens to anonymously share information on drug trafficking and consumption. Officials said hotspot areas would be identified through wastewater analysis in campuses and residential localities, while drone-assisted smart patrolling would be deployed for surveillance and enforcement.

MP0ST

PM SVANidhi completes six years, benefits over 75.5 lakh street vendors

OUR CORRESPONDENT

AGARTALA: The Prime Minister Street Vendor’s AtmaNirbhar Nidhi (PM SVANidhi), the flagship micro-credit scheme of the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA), has completed six years of providing financial support, digital inclusion and social security to street vendors across the country.

Later came a meeting led by Union minister Manohar Lal, overseeing housing and urban matters, alongside Tripura’s leader Manik Saha. Present were small traders helped through the PM SVANidhi initiative, arriving from Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Manipur, Mizoram, and local areas.

What followed was the handing over of financial tools - credit access and approved lending documents - to city sellers based in Tripura. The moment unfolded without ceremony, yet carried weight for those involved.



Introduced in June 2020, during the tenure of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, PM SVANidhi offers small interest-bearing credit without requiring security deposits to city-based hawkers. Despite its modest beginnings, the programme now plays a central role in bringing low-income metropolitan workers into regulated monetary systems. While not universally adopted, it continues shaping access to banking services for informal traders across urban India.

At the event, Manohar Lal spoke about the initiative being introduced as a response to the effort street vendors put into city economies. Not merely focused on smoother loan

availability, the PM SVANidhi aims - through steady support - to uphold respect, self-assurance, and monetary stability among those it serves.

So far, the program has reached above 75.5 lakh street vendors, based on government figures. Across India, lending without security stands at over 1.12 crore approved cases, while funds released have gone beyond Rs 17,800 crore.

Among street vendors in the North-East, financing exceeding Rs 430 crore has reached over 2.59 lakh individuals through loan programs. Disbursements in Tripura account for close to Rs 15 crore, covering more than 9,300 approved cases so far.

CA
Council of Architecture
Ministry of Education, Government of India.

NATA 2026

CHOOSE ARCHITECTURE

बनें राष्ट्र निर्माण के भागीदार

IMPORTANT PUBLIC NOTICE
CONDUCT OF NATA 2026 FOR ADMISSION TO B.Arch. COURSE

The Council of Architecture is conducting the National Aptitude Test in Architecture (NATA) 2026 for admission to the First Year of the 5-Year B.Arch. Degree Programme. Registration for NATA 2026 Phase-1 is currently open and will close on **09.06.2026**. The last examination under Phase-1 is scheduled to be held on **13.06.2026**.

The scores obtained in Phase-1 shall be considered for admission to B.Arch. programmes through the Centralized Admission Process (CAP) Counselling conducted by various admission authorities across States and Union Territories. **Candidates aspiring to pursue the B.Arch. Degree Programme are advised to complete their registration for NATA 2026 at the earliest, well before the closing date.**

WHO CAN APPLY?

12TH PASSED OR APPEARED STUDENTS WITH PHYSICS AND MATHEMATICS AS COMPULSORY SUBJECTS ALONG WITH EITHER CHEMISTRY OR BIOLOGY OR TECHNICAL VOCATIONAL SUBJECT OR COMPUTER SCIENCE OR INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY OR INFORMATICS PRACTICES OR ENGINEERING GRAPHICS OR BUSINESS STUDIES OR DIPLOMA STUDENTS WITH MATHEMATICS, SCORING ATLEAST 45% AGGREGATE, IN EACH CASE.

The NATA 2026 brochure containing eligibility criteria, syllabus and list of institutions admitting students to B.Arch. programme based on NATA score along with other important details is available on **www.nata.in** and **www.coa.gov.in**.

A candidate may appear in a maximum of two attempts. NATA 2026 score shall be valid for 2026-2027 academic year only.

New Delhi
Date : 31.05.2026

Registrar

एनएमडीसी
NMDC
Responsible Mining

INDIA'S FIRST

53 MILLION TONNES

IRON ORE PRODUCER

STANDALONE & CONSOLIDATED AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED 31ST MARCH, 2026

Pursuant to regulation 47 of the SEBI (Listing obligations and disclosure requirement) Regulations, 2015

The results can be accessed through the following link
https://www.nmdc.co.in/cms-admin/Upload/Financial_Result_Document/2b078d60fd6f430287361c214e7b5854_20260529205647560.pdf or scan

FY26 HIGHLIGHTS		FY26 Q4 HIGHLIGHTS	
33%	TURNOVER ₹ 31,554 Cr.	61%	TURNOVER ₹ 11,173 Cr.
11%	PAT ₹ 7,421 Cr.	35%	PAT ₹ 2,020 Cr.
21%	PRODUCTION 53.16 MnT	22%	PRODUCTION 16.27 MnT
13%	SALES 50.24 MnT	21%	SALES 15.30 MnT

NMDC Limited
(A Government of India Enterprise)

HEAD OFFICE: KHANU BHAVAN, MASAB TANK, HYDERABAD - 500028, INDIA.

CIN: L13100TG1958GOI001674 | www.nmdc.co.in | FOLLOW US ON:

By order of the Board NMDC Limited sd/-
(Amitava Mukherjee)
Chairman-Cum-Managing Director
DIN: 08265207
Date: 29 May, 2026
Place: Delhi

'NAVY COMMITTED TO INDIGENISATION'

Peak operational readiness top priority for new Navy chief

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Admiral Krishna Swaminathan on Sunday assumed charge as India's 27th Chief of the Naval Staff and immediately prioritised peak operational readiness as his top focus to navigate a fast-evolving regional maritime security landscape.

He succeeds Admiral Dinesh Kumar Tripathi, who superannated after 41 years of distinguished service.

Admiral Swaminathan was serving as the Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief of the Western Naval Command before taking charge of the top post. The new Navy Chief, speaking to reporters, described the regional security environment as "challenging, complex and unpredictable", and asserted that maintaining top-level operational readiness will be his highest priority.

"The Indian Navy stands vigilant to protect national interests wherever they are and is very actively deployed in a regional security environment that continues to remain challenging, complex, unpredictable, and uncertain," he told reporters, in an apparent reference to the West Asia situation.

"It shall be my highest priority to ensure that the Indian Navy maintains the highest level of operational readiness and combat effectiveness so that it can protect the nation's security and economic interests," he said.

Admiral Swaminathan said the Indian Navy is well set on a course of capability enhancement and modernisation.

"It shall be my endeavour to sustain the growth momentum of the Navy, consolidate all ongoing programmes, scale up



INSIGHT

» Admiral Swaminathan succeeds Admiral Dinesh Kumar Tripathi

» He was serving as the Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief of the Western Naval Command before taking the charge

where required, and sharpen our operational capabilities through the induction of niche and emerging technologies," he said.

"I will devote every single day of my life to making the Navy a better, stronger, sharper and more impactful service so that it can serve the interests of national security, national development and national economic prosperity," he said.

Admiral Swaminathan said the Navy is deeply committed to tri-services jointness, 'Atmanirbharata' and indigenisation. He also said that ensuring the welfare, well-being and personal growth of all naval personnel will be one of his priorities. He also praised Admiral Tripathi, describing him as one of the "finest" military professionals globally.

Admiral Swaminathan was commissioned into the Indian Navy on July 1, 1987, and is a specialist in communication and electronic Warfare.

He is an alumnus of the National Defence Academy, Khadakvasla; the Joint Services Command and Staff College, Shrivenham, United Kingdom;

the College of Naval Warfare, Karanja; and the US Naval War College, Newport.

A recipient of the Param Vishisht Seva Medal, Ati Vishisht Seva Medal and Vishisht Seva Medal, the Admiral has held several key operational, staff and training appointments in his naval career.

These include the command of missile vessels INS Vidyut and Vinash, the missile corvette INS Kulish, the guided missile destroyer INS Mysore and the aircraft carrier INS Vikramaditya.

On promotion to the rank of Rear Admiral, he served as the Chief Staff Officer (Training) at the Southern Naval Command's headquarters in Kochi. Vice Admiral Swaminathan was also instrumental in raising the Indian Naval Safety Team, which oversees operational safety across all verticals of the Navy. His educational qualifications include a BSc degree from Jawaharlal Nehru University; an MSc in Telecommunications from Cochín University of Science and Technology; and an MA in Defence Studies from King's College, London.

JAMMU REGION IN FOCUS

Pak beaming rogue telecom signals to aid terror networks, say officials

SRINAGAR/JAMMU: Pakistan is actively violating international telecommunication norms by deliberately beaming superfluous cellular signals across the border into Jammu and Kashmir aimed at providing a covert communication lifeline to terrorist groups operating in the Union territory, with a sharp focus on the Jammu region, officials said on Sunday.

Recent infiltration patterns, particularly in the south of the Pir Panjal range, indicate there has been a significant surge in telecom towers erected along the Line of Control (LoC) in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK), whose signals reach various Jammu jails where hardcore terrorists are lodged.

While the mountains of the Kashmir Valley naturally block most of these rogue signals, the flat topography of the Jammu



plains allows the frequencies to penetrate deep into Indian territory.

Signal traces have been detected in border districts, including Kathua, Rajouri and Poonch, and as far inland as the highly sensitive Kot Bawal jail area in Jammu, the officials said.

The officials said that jammers used at present in some prisons in the terror-hit region have been unable to block the signals and choke illicit communication by inmates as smuggled mobile devices reportedly continued to func-

'There has been a significant surge in telecom towers erected along the LoC in PoK'

tion inside blanketed prison zones. There are 14 jails in Jammu and Kashmir, besides two correctional homes.

The officials said that since Jammu and Kashmir has a hyper-sensitive threat environment, further complicated by cross-border signals, drone-assisted devices and shifting telecom spectra, there was a need to install next-generation facility rather than traditional, static jammers that risk compromising security while cutting off nearby civilian communities.

The officials said that the

new technology is designed to pinpoint and neutralise active rogue devices within specific zones. In 2019-20, the security agencies had focused on rogue communication networks from across the border and successfully dismantled them after cracking the encryption, the officials said, adding that the present attempts will meet a similar fate.

The officials said that the strategic placement of telecom towers by Pakistan along the International Border and Line of Control violates Article 45 of the Constitution of the International Telecommunication Union (ITU), a United Nations body which mandates that all 193 member states take necessary steps to prevent the transmission of false, misleading or superfluous signals, and actively cooperate in locating unauthorised stations. PFI

Kedarnath Yatra halted due to bad weather in Uttarakhand

RUDRAPRAYAG: The Kedarnath Yatra was temporarily halted on Sunday, and pilgrims were stopped at safe locations after the IMD issued an orange alert, forecasting heavy rains and storms in the region.

The administration directed officials to accommodate all pilgrims currently on the route at the nearest holding centres. District Disaster Management Officer Nandan Singh Rajwar said the administration was fully prepared to deal with any adverse situation arising from the weather conditions.

"Following the orange alert... instructions have been issued to stop all pilgrims at the nearest safe locations. Sector officers deployed in landslide-prone areas... have been directed to ensure no pilgrim moves forward until the weather clears," he said. MPOST

Saini visits Dera Beas, offers prayers at Kapurthala temple

MPOST BUREAU



Haryana CM Noyab Singh Saini pays obeisance at Mata Bhadrakali Temple in Kapurthala, Punjab on Sunday

MPOST

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday visited Dera Radha Soami Satsang Beas and called on Dera chief Baba Gurinder Singh Dhillon, seeking his blessings and discussing various social and spiritual issues. Later, the Chief Minister visited the revered Mata Bhadrakali Temple in Kapurthala, where he offered prayers for the happiness, prosperity, peace and well-being of the people of Haryana and the country. Saini said India's rich spiritual and cultural heritage plays an important role in fostering social unity and spreading positive values across society.

During his visit to

Kapurthala, the Chief Minister also interacted with residents and traders in the Circular Road Market area. Locals greeted him warmly, and a large number of people turned up during the interaction.

Addressing citizens, Saini said his government remains committed to public welfare,

development and good governance, with the interests of common people at the centre of its policies and programmes.

Tarun Bhandari, Political Secretary to the Chief Minister, along with local dignitaries, administrative officials and several citizens, was present during the visit.

U'khand: SDRF rescues pilgrims stranded in swollen river in Champawat

DEHRADUN: A major tragedy was averted at the Sri Reetha Sahib Gurdwara in Champawat district on Sunday after the rescue of more than 50 pilgrims who were trapped in a swollen river during the annual Jod Mela, officials said.

According to officials, a State Disaster Response Force (SDRF) team had been deployed at the fair venue in advance, keeping in view the heavy rush of pilgrims and weather conditions.

This advance deployment proved crucial when sudden rainfall in the region caused the water levels of the Ladhya and Ratiya rivers to rise.

Over 50 pilgrims, who were bathing at the confluence of the two rivers before heading to the gurdwara for darshan, found themselves trapped in the middle of the surging waters. Several vehicles parked near the riverbed were also caught in the rising water, triggering panic.

An SDRF team immediately reached the spot and launched a rescue operation. Despite the strong currents and challenging conditions, the personnel safely escorted all the stranded pilgrims across the river, the officials said, adding that the team also assisted in moving the trapped vehicles to safer ground.

Local and traffic police were informed immediately, after which barriers were placed on both sides to regulate movement and prevent other devotees from approaching the river.

All individuals were evacuated safely and no casualties were reported, SDRF Commandant Arpan Yaduwanshi said, adding that the advance deployment helped them ensure a swift response. In view of the continuous rainfall across the state, all SDRF units have been directed to maintain a high state of alert, monitor sensitive areas, and ensure immediate action in case of emergencies, he added. MPOST

UP: Power bills set to increase as UPPCL levies 10% surcharge

BISWAJEET BANERJEE



LUCKNOW: Electricity consumers in Uttar Pradesh will have to pay more from June, with the Uttar Pradesh Power Corporation Limited (UPPCL) imposing a 10 per cent Fuel and Power Purchase Adjustment Surcharge (FPPAS) amid rising power procurement costs and peak summer demand.

UPPCL said the levy is aimed at recovering higher expenses incurred on power generation and procurement due to rising fuel prices and increased electricity purchase costs. FPPAS is a regulatory mechanism that allows distribution companies to pass on additional fuel and power purchase costs to consumers through monthly bills.

The decision has trig-

gered strong opposition from consumer groups. The Uttar Pradesh State Electricity Consumers Council demanded an immediate rollback, saying consumers are already struggling with soaring temperatures, power shortages and inflation. Council chairman Awadhesh Kumar Verma pointed out that consumers had already borne a 10 per cent fuel surcharge in February this year and argued that another levy within a few months

would place an undue burden on households.

"The people of the state are facing severe heat, electricity shortages and inflation. Increasing electricity charges at such a time will adversely affect ordinary consumers," Verma said.

He claimed that while the Uttar Pradesh Electricity Regulatory Commission (UPERC) had approved an actual power purchase cost of Rs 4.94 per unit, UPPCL procured power in March 2026 at around Rs 5.86 per unit, resulting in an additional burden of nearly Rs 1,610 crore on consumers.

Verma also sought a probe into power purchases made during March, alleging that electricity was regularly being procured from private generating companies at elevated rates.

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has held that cases involving the trafficking of children for Commercial Sexual Exploitation (CSE) can attract charges under the stringent POCSO Act, alongside the relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act.

A bench of Justices J B Pardiwala and R Mahadevan on Friday issued a slew of directions to mitigate the concerns of sex workers, while clarifying the legal framework for the prosecution of perpetrators and the rehabilitation of victims.

It said the consent of an adult victim to the intended exploitation is irrelevant if

any of the listed "means," like the use of threat, force, other forms of coercion, abduction, fraud, deception, abuse of power, abuse of a position of vulnerability, or the giving or receiving of payments or benefits to achieve the consent of a person, are used. "The consent of a child victim of trafficking is irrelevant, regardless of whether or not 'means' have been used... Lack of consent is not an element of the crime of trafficking in persons."

"Thus, the focus should be firmly on the actions and intentions of the perpetrators, and once the elements of the crime of trafficking, including the use of one of the identified means (coercion, deception, etc.), are proven, any defence or allegation that the victim 'consented' should be deemed to be irrelevant," it said.

The bench said a person's awareness that they are being employed in the sex industry or prostitution does not exclude them from being a victim of trafficking, as they may have been deceived about the conditions of work, which later turned out to be exploitative.

The top court said Article 23 of the Constitution prohibits trafficking in human beings,

A bench of Justices J B Pardiwala and R Mahadevan issued a slew of directions to mitigate concerns of sex workers

evant," it said. The bench said a person's awareness that they are being employed in the sex industry or prostitution does not exclude them from being a victim of trafficking, as they may have been deceived about the conditions of work, which later turned out to be exploitative.

The top court said Article 23 of the Constitution prohibits trafficking in human beings,

beggars, and all other similar forms of forced labour, and its ambit is wide and unlimited. It strikes at human trafficking in whatever form it is found and is enforceable not only against the State but against any private individuals engaged in such practices.

The bench noted that while dealing with Article 23 or legislations enacted to give effect to it, the court has consistently adopted a liberal interpretation, presuming and extending protections and benefits to all those in conditions of exploitation.

"When the victim of trafficking for CSE is a child, the provisions of the POCSO Act may apply alongside Sections 143 and 144 BNS respectively and/or the provisions of ITTPA," it said.

Uttar Pradesh: Rajeev Krishna appointed DGP

UP gets full-time police chief after 4 yrs

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The Uttar Pradesh government has appointed 1991-batch IPS officer Rajeev Krishna as the state's Director General of Police (DGP), ending a four-year wait for a full-time police chief. Rajeev Krishna has been serving as acting DGP since June 2025 and will now hold the post on a permanent basis. The appointment order was issued by Additional Chief Secretary (Home) Sanjay Prasad. Rajeev Krishna will continue to hold an additional charge as Director of the Vigilance Establishment.

The appointment comes after the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) sent a panel of three senior IPS officers to the state government following a meeting held on May 26. The panel included 1990-batch IPS officer Renuka Mishra and 1991-batch officers Piyush Anand and Rajeev Krishna. Rajeev Krishna was widely regarded as the front-runner for the post.

After consultations at the

Krishna has been serving as acting DGP since June 1, 2025

government level, Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath approved Rajeev Krishna's name for the state's top police position. He is considered one of the chief minister's trusted officers and has held several key assignments in the state police force.

Rajeev Krishna has been serving as acting DGP since June 1, 2025. Before that, he simultaneously handled the responsibilities of Director General of Intelligence and Chairman of the Police Recruitment and Promotion Board.

A seasoned officer with more than three decades of service, Rajeev Krishna is known for his extensive administrative and field experience. He has served as police chief in several important districts, including Lucknow, Mathura, Etawah, Agra and Noida.

UP TO 9 TIMES MORE AT RISK

'New tobacco products luring children'

KEY POINTS

» The experts said the tobacco and nicotine industry is increasingly using flavours, sleek designs, digital promotion and other tactics to make its products appealing to young people

» The warning comes as the world marks this year's



World No Tobacco Day

» 'Many people continue to underestimate the risks associated with smokeless tobacco products'

cence or early adulthood.

"That is why the marketing tactics are designed to create curiosity, experimentation and eventually addiction," she said on Sunday during a webinar organised by Tobacco Free India, a citizens' initiative.

She said the challenge today extends beyond traditional tobacco products and includes newer nicotine products that are often perceived as less harmful and risky than they actually are. Former Chief of the National Cancer Institute in Delhi, Dr Alok Thakar, said tobacco continues to impose a heavy burden on India's health system. "As oncologists, we witness the consequences of tobacco use every

day. Many tobacco-related cancers are preventable, yet thousands of families continue to suffer because addiction often begins at a young age," he said.

In a separate development, the World Health Organization (WHO) announced the World No Tobacco Day Award 2026 for the ICMR-National Institute of Cancer Prevention and Research (NICPR) in recognition of its contribution to tobacco control and cancer prevention. The award is among the highest recognitions conferred by the WHO in the field of tobacco control.

Describing the recognition as an encouragement for the wider tobacco control com-

munity, Dr Singh said, "It reinforces the importance of sustained efforts in research, awareness, policy support and public engagement. India has made important progress, but the tobacco and nicotine landscape continues to evolve and requires continued vigilance."

Dr Thakar cautioned that many people continue to underestimate the risks associated with smokeless tobacco products. "In India, a significant proportion of oral cancer cases are linked to products such as gutka, khaini and similar forms of smokeless tobacco. The packaging may change and the marketing may evolve, but the health consequences remain serious," he said.

Former NCERT Director Professor JBS Rajput said the issue should be viewed not only as a health challenge but also as an educational and social concern. "The WHO finding that children are nine times more likely to be attracted to new tobacco and nicotine products is a wake-up call for society. We cannot leave this battle to the health authorities alone. Schools, parents and communities have a critical role in helping children..." AGENCIES



EDITORIAL
A DANGEROUS
PRECEDENT

The images emerging from West Bengal in recent weeks are troubling not merely because they show political workers being assaulted, humiliated or paraded through the streets, but because they reveal something deeper about the state of democratic culture in India. Whatever the immediate provocation, however intense the public anger, the spectacle of mob justice replacing due process should concern every citizen. A democracy governed by laws cannot permit individuals or groups to assume the role of judge, jury and executioner. Yet, increasingly, political violence is not only being tolerated but also celebrated. Social media platforms amplify such incidents, supporters of rival camps cheer them on, and public discourse becomes a contest of who deserves humiliation rather than who deserves justice. The danger lies not merely in the violence itself, but in the growing acceptance of violence as a legitimate political language. When political opponents are reduced to enemies and public humiliation becomes a form of entertainment, democratic institutions begin to erode from within.

West Bengal's political history offers ample warning about where such trends lead. Political violence did not begin with the current dispensation, nor was it absent during previous regimes. The state has long carried the burden of a confrontational political culture. The turbulent years of the Naxalite movement in the late 1960s and early 1970s witnessed intense clashes between the state and radical groups. Subsequent decades under the Left Front were often marked by allegations of cadre dominance and political intimidation, particularly in rural areas. The violent events at places such as Nandigram and Singur became defining moments in Bengal's political consciousness. When the Trinamool Congress replaced the Left Front in 2011, many hoped that a new political culture would emerge. Instead, accusations of political violence merely shifted direction. Election-related clashes, local turf wars and attacks on party workers continued to be reported with alarming regularity. The political colours changed, but the methods often remained depressingly familiar. This continuity should force a difficult question: has Bengal normalised political violence to such an extent that every new government simply inherits and perpetuates the same machinery?

The temptation to justify such behaviour is understandable but dangerous. Every political camp possesses its catalogue of grievances. Supporters of one party point to past excesses committed by another. Opponents respond with their own list of victims and injustices. In this environment, violence acquires a veneer of legitimacy because it is portrayed as payback rather than wrongdoing. Yet retribution is not justice. Justice operates through institutions, evidence, courts and due process. Retribution operates through emotion, anger and collective punishment. Democracies survive because they insist on the former even when the latter appears more satisfying. The moment a society begins to excuse assaults, public shaming or mob action because the victim "deserves it", it abandons the principle of equal protection under law. What remains is a hierarchy of rights determined by political affiliation. Such a system inevitably turns against everyone. Those who celebrate the humiliation of opponents today may discover tomorrow that political winds have shifted and the same methods are being used against them. History repeatedly demonstrates that the cycle of vengeance rarely ends with one side's victory; it merely changes targets.

The role of public discourse in encouraging this cycle deserves scrutiny. Social media has transformed political conflict into a form of mass entertainment. Images of assaults, confrontations and public humiliation circulate with remarkable speed, often accompanied by triumphant commentary. Many users who would never engage in violence themselves nonetheless become enthusiastic spectators. Political outrage is rewarded with visibility, while calls for restraint are dismissed as weakness or false equivalence. The result is a culture in which democratic norms gradually lose their moral authority. This phenomenon is not unique to Bengal. Across India and indeed across many democracies, political polarisation has encouraged citizens to view institutions with suspicion and opponents with contempt. But Bengal's history makes it particularly vulnerable. A society accustomed to treating politics as a zero-sum battle risks becoming trapped in a permanent state of conflict where every election resembles a transfer of power between rival camps rather than a peaceful expression of democratic choice.

The challenge, therefore, extends beyond any single party or government. Law enforcement agencies must act firmly against political violence regardless of the victim's affiliation. Political leadership across the spectrum must reject the language of vengeance and resist the temptation to exploit public anger for short-term gain. Equally important, citizens must abandon the habit of applauding behaviour they would condemn if directed at their own side. Democracy demands consistency. If mob intimidation is wrong when one's supporters are targeted, it is equally wrong when one's opponents are targeted. West Bengal's tragedy is not simply that political violence recurs; it is that each generation convinces itself that this time the violence is justified. The state deserves better than an endless cycle of retaliation. It deserves institutions strong enough to enforce accountability, politics mature enough to tolerate dissent and citizens wise enough to recognise that jungle raj does not disappear when power changes hands. It merely acquires a new set of occupants. The true test of democracy is not how it treats its friends, but how it treats its adversaries. Bengal, and indeed India, would do well to remember that distinction.

TALKING
SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN

THE WRITER
IS A VETERAN
JOURNALIST AND
COMMUNICATIONS
SPECIALIST

India is still attracting foreign investors, but the era of patient and productive capital inflow appears to be ending. This is not because Indians are investing overseas, but because foreign firms are pulling out profits or exiting

"Capital is timid indeed. It flies from uncertainty."
— James Madison

There used to be a reassuring distinction in India's economic story. Foreign Portfolio Investment was portrayed as a nervous traveller, quick to arrive in times of optimism and quicker to flee at the first sign of turbulence. Foreign Direct Investment, on the other hand, was a steadfast guest. It built factories, hired workers, transferred technology and devoted itself to the future. The distinction is now collapsing.

In a development that should concern policymakers, economists and ordinary Indians alike, India's net Foreign Direct Investment has all but evaporated. The numbers are startling. According to Reserve Bank of India data, net FDI plunged from \$28 billion in FY 2022-23 to barely \$1 billion in FY 2024-25, despite gross inflows remaining robust. Even the rebound to \$7.7 billion in FY 2025-26 remains a fraction of what India once considered normal. The reason is not that investors have stopped coming. It is that they are now taking money back home almost as quickly as they bring it in. Repatriations and disinvestments surged to over \$51 billion in FY 2024-25, while Indian firms themselves accelerated overseas investments.

This is not an accounting anomaly. It is a warning signal. The Silent Exit

Today's India finds itself in a paradox. The country continues to attract headlines as the world's fastest-growing major economy. Stock markets remain buoyant. Unicorns abound. Announcements around infrastructure dominate political speeches. But beneath the celebratory optics, foreign investors appear eager to monetise, exit and repatriate.

Part of this is structural. India's post-pandemic market boom allowed multinational corporations to list at rich valuations. Once listed, early investors found an efficient exit route. For global capital, unlike political rhetoric, is not sentimental. It seeks returns, liquidity and predictability. It is hard-nosed, num-

Runaway Capital

India's foreign investment story is no longer about money coming in, but about it quietly moving out – raising questions on growth, trust and policy credibility



Indian capital itself is increasingly looking outward, with outward FDI by Indian firms jumping to over \$28 billion in FY 2024-25

bers-driven. India gave investors handsome returns. Investors merrily booked profits. But the sheer scale of the outflow now suggests something deeper than routine profit-taking.

MNCs appear to now view India less as a long-horizon manufacturing destination and more as a mature financial market where capital can be (re)cycled efficiently. That is a profound shift. The old FDI model was based on permanence. The new model resembles sophisticated arbitrage.

The geography of these investments also reveals the reality beneath the din of the rhetoric. A major chunk of FDI travels through hubs like Singapore and Mauritius, jurisdictions valued less for productive capability and more for tax efficiency and treaty structuring. This raises itch-in-the-pants questions about how much of India's FDI represents a long-term productive pledge and how much it reflects base financial engineering.

The consequences extend beyond foreign exchange balances. FDI is not valued because dollars enter India. It matters because it signals confidence in India's future productive capacity. When net FDI collapses despite strong gross inflows, the message is variegated. It reveals that while investors may still believe India offers profitable exits, they are not sure about staying invested for decades.

Statistical Shadows

At the same moment that India's FDI story has begun to fray, another itchy debate has resurfaced – the credibility of the growth numbers.

Economists, including former Chief Economic Advisor Arvind Subramanian, feel India's annual growth between 2012 and 2023 may have been overstated by 1.5 to 2 percentage points, while the boom years between 2005 and 2011 may have been underestimated.

The debate is contentious and widely disputed. But the questions raised are serious enough to merit attention. One criticism is that India's formal sector was used as a proxy for the vast informal economy, even after shocks such as demonetisation, GST disruptions and the pandemic hit small enterprises. Another concerns the parameters used to calculate real growth, especially in services-heavy sectors.

Why does this matter for FDI? Because investment decisions ultimately rest on trust in data. Investors can tolerate political uncertainty, tax disputes and even bureaucratic friction. What they don't tolerate is opacity. If headline GDP growth appears disconnected from employment growth, consumption, wage growth or capacity utilisation, investors begin asking harder questions. Doubting. Worrying. Exiting.

Some of the puzzles haunting the Indian economy stem from this disconnect. If growth has indeed been spectacular, why has private investment gone hesitant? Why has mass consumption stayed uneven? Why does unemployment remain high? Why has the informal economy struggled to recover its vitality? These are not abstract academic questions. They go to the heart of

whether India's growth model is broad-based, or whether it is concentrated in financial markets and a narrow formal elite economy.

Capital Flight

There is another layer to this unfolding story. Indian capital itself is increasingly looking outward, with outward FDI by Indian firms jumping to over \$28 billion in FY 2024-25. Indian corporations are expanding aggressively into global finance, manufacturing and business services. On the surface, this reflects growing corporate ambition. Scratch the veneer a bit and it hints at an erosion of domestic confidence.

When domestic firms seek opportunities abroad and foreign investors repatriate gains, any economy enters a dangerous cycle. Domestic capital becomes globally mobile while foreign capital becomes opportunistic. The result is an economy that is globally integrated but internally fragile. For India, this fragility is dangerous, with employment growth remaining a defining economic challenge. India does not merely need capital inflows; it needs sticky capital – money that builds supply chains, manufacturing ecosystems, research capabilities and labour-intensive industries.

And that requires something deeper than tax incentives or headline reforms. It requires institutional trust.

Policy Reset

India's FDI policy was designed for a different era, one where attracting capital itself was the principal objective. Today, the challenge is no longer that. India is too large, too dynamic and too strategically important to be ignored. The challenge is retaining productive investment and ensuring that capital truly deepens the domestic economy. That demands a new policy imagination, especially in FDI.

India must distinguish between transactional and transformational capital. Funds merely routed through tax havens for short-term gains cannot be treated similar to monies that create enduring assets. Incentive structures should reward tech transfer, value addition, employment intensity and

long-term reinvestment commitments. Data credibility is equally critical. A great economy cannot afford to depend on statistical triumphs. Transparent methodologies, informal sector measurement and institutional credibility are not technocratic luxuries; they are economic necessities.

The world's largest investors do not study only growth rates. They also study legal predictability, regulatory stability, judicial efficiency and institutional honesty. In an era of geopolitical fragmentation and supply-chain realignment, India possesses a unique opportunity to become the world's most trusted democratic production hub. But trust is a funny animal: it does not like to coexist with opacity.

Hard Reckoning

India's present moment demands honesty, not misplaced celebration. The collapse in net FDI is not a catastrophe. Not yet. Gross inflows remain strong and India continues to enjoy structural advantages – a vast domestic market, demographic scale, digital infrastructure and geopolitical relevance. But the warning signs are unmistakable, and they are here to stay (for a while, at the least).

For long, India has mistaken financial enthusiasm for developmental validation. Rising stock indices were treated as proof of economic depth. Unicorn valuations became substitutes for manufacturing strength. Headline GDP figures crowded out conversations about jobs, incomes and informal distress.

But capital is a funny animal too: it eventually reveals what slogans conceal.

The question before India is not whether the world is interested in its market. It obviously is. The question is whether the world still sees India as a long-term productive destination or merely as a quick, profitable financial trade. The answer will define not only the future of FDI, but also the credibility of India's economic story. And in the years ahead, credibility may prove more valuable than capital itself.

The writer can be reached on narayanrajeev2006@gmail.com. Views expressed are personal

STRATEGIC
HORIZONS



SHANTANU MUKHARJI

THE WRITER IS
A RETIRED IPS
OFFICER, ADVISER
NATSTRAT, AND A
FORMER NATIONAL
SECURITY ADVISOR
IN MAURITIUS

Dhaka seems to be displaying a renewed sense of diplomatic maturity, while both countries are planning a series of meetings in the coming weeks

A New Diplomatic Equation?

China's growing role in Bangladesh, including on Teesta discussions, presents opportunities for Dhaka while raising strategic questions in India



Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman's visit to Beijing highlights the expanding China-Bangladesh cooperation

Foreign Minister of Bangladesh, Khalilur Rahman, has very recently concluded a three-day official visit to China, marking his first-ever trip to China since the new Bangladeshi government under the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) assumed office in February this year. The visit signifies the stability, continuity, and pragmatic orientation of China-Bangladesh relations, as perceived by official circles in both countries.

In the wake of the political transition in August 2024, Bangladesh continued to maintain consistent engagement with China across official and non-governmental channels. At the governmental level, in January 2025, Touhid Hossain, then Adviser for Foreign Affairs in Bangladesh's interim government, visited Beijing and held talks with his Chinese counterpart, Wang Yi. In addition, major Bangladeshi political parties, civil society organisations, academic institutions, research centres, student associations, and media representatives have continued to engage with their Chinese counterparts in various fields. These multifaceted interactions have significantly enhanced mutual understanding and reinforced bilateral trust. These trends indicate considerable promise for further strengthening relations between the two countries.

Meanwhile, according to Zhang Xiaoyu, Director of the South Asian Communication Studies Centre at the Academy of International and Regional Communication Studies, Communication University of China, political stability is instrumental to Bangladesh's long-term development. He has opined that, following this year's peaceful general election and orderly transfer of power, Bangladesh has entered a new phase of development. Accordingly, cultivating and managing constructive relations with major countries has become a central priority for the new government. Coincidentally, this year also marks the 10th anniversary of Bangladesh's participation in the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI).

Furthermore, previous years witnessed tens of billions of dollars in committed investments, primarily directed towards large-scale infrastructure projects in transportation, energy, and information and communications technology. A series of transformative projects, some implemented directly under BRI frameworks and others enabled through BRI-facilitated financing, technical collaboration, or policy coordination, have significantly enhanced Bangladesh's transport networks and power generation and distribution capacity. Looking ahead, bilateral cooperation holds substantial potential for further refinement and deepening, particularly in emerging priority areas such as the digital economy.

In addition, the political mutual trust between the two countries manifests itself across multiple dimensions. Bangladesh firmly supports the One-China principle and opposes "Taiwan independence", a position that is particularly important for safeguarding China's core interests. The two countries have also coordinated closely on broader regional and global issues, including efforts to resolve the Middle East conflict, and have reached a shared understanding on key principles such as upholding multilateralism, resolving disputes through peaceful means, and advancing the vision of a multipolar world order.

In his meeting with Bangladeshi Foreign Minister Rahman on May 6, Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi clearly stated that China respects Bangladesh's independence, sovereignty, and national dignity, as well as the development path and political system chosen by its people. He reaffirmed China's support for Bangladesh in pursuing an independent foreign policy. According to Rahman, the new Bangladeshi government attaches high importance to its relations with China and stands ready to strengthen coordination with Beijing to jointly safeguard multilateralism.

During the visit, the two sides reaffirmed their commitment to the purposes and principles of the United Nations Charter, multilateralism, democracy in international relations, and the peaceful settlement of disputes. On regional issues, Bangladesh highly appreciated China's proposals for safeguarding peace and stability in the Middle East, while both sides called for an immediate and comprehensive ceasefire, protection of non-military targets, restoration of peace and security, and the maintenance of normal passage through the Strait of Hormuz. Regarding the Rohingya crisis, China stated that it would continue supporting Bangladesh and Myanmar in finding a mutually acceptable solution to the issue of forcibly displaced people from Rakhine State

through dialogue and consultations. It also pledged to continue supporting repatriation efforts to the best of its capabilities. Khalilur Rahman invited the Chinese Foreign Minister to visit Bangladesh at a mutually convenient time.

Most significantly, however, the meeting highlighted that the Teesta River issue could offer an opportunity for Bangladesh to cooperate with China. Dhaka has stated that it has sought China's involvement and support in the Teesta River Comprehensive Management and Restoration Project (TRCMRP), while the Chinese side has expressed its willingness to participate proactively in the initiative. This development appears significant and cannot be ignored by strategic thinkers concerned with India's geopolitical interests.

That said, any use of China's "good offices" in the Teesta water issue may not be entirely comfortable for India. However, this is not a new development. During the tenure of former Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, China had also expressed interest in offering technical expertise on the Teesta issue. Even today, such gestures may need to be diplomatically neutralised, with India taking the lead in addressing the matter. Now that a different provincial government is in place in West Bengal, it is possible that the issue will be handled more effectively, with complete coordination between the Central and State governments and without any significant role for China.

It would appear from the Bangladesh Foreign Minister's recent Beijing visit that the new Bangladeshi administration is moving closer to China, possibly as part of a delicate diplomatic balancing act between India and China. As Sino-Bangladesh relations continue to warm, however, there appears to be little reason for concern. Dhaka seems to be displaying a renewed sense of diplomatic maturity, while both countries are planning a series of meetings in the coming weeks. They

also intend to re-engage after relations had deteriorated during Bangladesh's interim government. This intention was reflected in remarks made by India's Foreign Secretary, Vikram Misri, during an interaction with a Bangladeshi media delegation at the Ministry of External Affairs in New Delhi on May 4.

At present, the two countries maintain more than 40 bilateral mechanisms covering issues such as water sharing, trade, border management, and consular services. Many of these mechanisms remained dormant during the interim period, when India also drastically reduced the number of visas issued to Bangladeshi citizens. Following the BNP's victory in the February elections, both sides began easing restrictions. Bangladesh resumed issuing all categories of visas to Indians. India, however, has yet to fully restore visas for Bangladeshis.

Trade restrictions and political rhetoric also strained ties during the interim government. The situation began to improve after the election, with Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman visiting India in early April and holding talks with his counterparts. Addressing the media delegation, Foreign Secretary Misri stated that India sought a constructive, positive, and pragmatic relationship with Bangladesh, placing people at the centre of bilateral engagement. Noting that the two countries share more than 4,000 kilometres of border and 54 transboundary rivers, and are major trading partners, he further emphasised that India wished to advance and modernise its economic partnership with Bangladesh.

These recent developments and statements carry hope and a marked sense of optimism that merits further consolidation of bilateral ties between India and Bangladesh. Judging by the current trajectory, any signs of Bangladesh's growing proximity to China seem unlikely to diminish the prospects for developing stronger and more robust Indo-Bangladesh relations.

Views expressed are personal

AMID REPORTS OF CHANGES TO PACT

US close to ‘very good deal’ with Iran: Trump

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump has said the US and Iran are close to a “very good deal,” but if Washington does not get what it wants, then it will “end it in a different way.”

Trump’s remarks came during an interview to his daughter-in-law Lara Trump, which was telecast on Fox News on Saturday night.

“We’re close to a very good deal. If you’re going to be in a hurry, you’re not going to make a good deal, and slowly but surely, we’re getting what we want — and if we don’t get what we want, we’re going to end it a different way,” Trump said.

Trump said the Iranians are “good negotiators,” but argued that the United States now holds “all the cards” because Iran has been “militarily defeated.”

“But we’re close to a very good deal. If we can make it, good. Otherwise we just start up with the Department of War as we call it,” the US President said.

Trump said the Iranians had stated they were not developing a nuclear weapon, but he countered by asking what if they bought one.

“I said, well what happens if you buy a nuclear weapon? So now it says we will not develop or in any way purchase a military weapon. That’s a big difference,” he said.

The American leader insisted that the US has “significant leverage” over Iran, as their navy and air force were “completely destroyed”. However, he said, the US has not fully dismantled Iran’s military because some of the leadership was more moderate.



US President Donald Trump holds a meeting

AP/PTI

Highlights

- » Trump’s remarks came during an interview to his daughter-in-law Lara Trump
- » Trump said the Iranians are ‘good negotiators,’ but argued that the United States now holds ‘all the cards’
- » The American leader insisted that the US has ‘significant leverage’ over Iran, as their navy and air force were ‘completely destroyed’

Trump said the US had targeted Iran’s more extreme elements and key leadership.

The US President held a meeting with his top cabinet colleagues and officers of the armed forces in the situation room on Friday but it concluded without any clarity on future actions.

US media outlet Axios reported that Trump asked for several amendments to the deal his envoys reached with their Iranian counterparts.

Trump wants the deal and expects to finalize it soon, but is keen to strengthen several points that are important to him – particularly around Iran’s nuclear material, Axios reported quoting two US officials.

Trump’s request has launched another round of back-and-forth between the parties that could last several days.

“It’s more specifics about how the US gets the material and the timing,” a senior administration official said, referring to the enriched uranium.

The second source told Axios that Trump also wants to amend some of the wording around the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz – which hosts roughly one-fifth of the world’s energy supplies in normal times. AGENCIES

Israel captures strategic castle in Lebanon

BEIRUT: Israeli troops have captured a strategic mountain topped with a Crusader-built castle in southern Lebanon in their deepest incursion into the country in more than a quarter century, the military said Sunday.

The capture of Beaufort castle near the city of Nabatiyeh came after days of intense fighting and airstrikes in nearby villages where Israeli troops fought Hezbollah members in the rugged area.

It marks a major gain for Israel in the latest Israel-Hezbollah war, which began in early March. Israel and Lebanon have been at war since Israel was created in 1948, and are currently holding direct talks in Washington.

The Israeli push came despite a nominal ceasefire that has been in place since April 17 and just days before the next round of talks are set to be held at the State Department on June 2 and 3.

The Israeli army’s Arabic spokesperson Avichay Adraee posted a photograph on X showing Israeli troops walking outside the castle, and Defence Minister Israel Katz wrote on X that they had raised an Israeli flag over the castle.

Israeli troops previously captured the castle in 1982 and held it until they withdrew from Lebanon in 2000.

The Israeli military said in a statement that it launched an operation a few days ago in the Beaufort Ridge and the Suluki valley further south with the aim of dismantling Hezbollah infrastructure and removing “direct threats to Israeli civilians”. AGENCIES

Ukraine hits Russian energy targets; denies striking nuclear plant

The refinery belongs to Russia’s state oil enterprise

KYIV: Ukraine denied Moscow’s claims on Sunday that a Ukrainian drone struck the Russian-controlled Zaporizhzhia nuclear plant, as Kyiv launched fresh strikes overnight on Russian energy sites.

Ukraine’s General Staff on Sunday said Ukrainian drones had struck the Saratov oil refinery in southwestern Russia, causing a “large-scale fire.” It said the extent of the damage was being clarified, and claimed the refinery has been supplying Moscow’s war effort.

The refinery belongs to Russia’s state oil enterprise, Rosneft, and produces diesel and gasoline among other types of fuel.

The Russian local governor, Roman Busargin, said Ukrainian drones had damaged “civilian infrastructure,” but did not immediately give details. Astra, an independent Russian news channel, said an oil refinery was on fire in the city of Saratov.



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

“RUSSIAN NEWS CHANNEL, SAID AN OIL REFINERY WAS ON FIRE IN THE CITY OF SARATOV”

Ukraine has stepped up its attacks on Russia’s oil and

gas facilities in recent months, arguing the energy sector both funds and directly fuels Moscow’s more than 4-year-old invasion.

Drone debris also set fire to a fuel depot in Russia’s southwestern Rostov region, which borders Russian-occupied eastern Ukraine, local Gov. Yuriy Slyusar reported on Telegram on Sunday. AGENCIES

WHO hails 5 Ebola recoveries as new treatment centre opens in east Congo

BUNIA: Five patients have recovered from a rare type of Ebola virus, the head of the World Health Organization said Sunday during a visit to Bunia in eastern Congo, a city at the heart of an outbreak.

“Four people will be discharged today and there was one that was discharged the day before yesterday,” WHO

Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus said during the opening of a new Ebola treatment centre in Bunia, the capital of Ituri province.

“Of course, we’re still working on vaccines and treatments but that doesn’t mean that people cannot recover from Ebola,” he added. The WHO said Friday a patient had recovered from the Bundibugyo virus, the current species of Ebola, which has no approved treatment or vaccine. It was the first documented recovery of a confirmed Bundibugyo patient during the current outbreak.

The health organisation said authorities have reported 134 confirmed cases in Congo and neighbouring Uganda, including 18 confirmed deaths as of May 29. Baraka Bulambulu, one of those who recovered, told The Associated Press on Sunday that community members feared contracting an unknown illness from them, keeping their distance while delivering food and medicine. AGENCIES

Iran war forces farmers seek fertilizer alternatives from cow dung to compost

DAKAR: When Senegalese farmer Abou Sow first watched US missiles strike Iran on social media, he had a sinking feeling it would soon affect agriculture in the West African nation. Since the war began on February 28, fertilizer prices have risen by 40%.

Sow was better prepared than most. Eight years ago, he gave up chemical fertilizers for organic compost and other natural sources. He now rallies farmers in Senegal to buy manure from local herders and gives advice on how to make a rich compost, picking out wriggling worms – a healthy sign.

“We can’t afford to wait for a ceasefire,” Sow said. “It’s risky to depend on chemical fertilizers.” Iran’s grip on the Strait of Hor-



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

muz has affected the supply of natural gas, essential for making chemical fertilizer, as well as global shipping.

The Gulf region produces 30% of globally traded chem-

ical fertilizer, according to the International Food Policy Research Institute, and global prices have increased by 50%, according to the World Bank’s fertilizer price index.

“The clock is ticking very hard,” said Maximo Torero, chief economist at the UN’s Food and Agriculture Organization, as concerns grow about food security. Experts say a shift away from chemical fertilizer could have wider benefits, as its production and usage create significant greenhouse gas emissions, the main driver of climate change. Natural fertilizers, by contrast, can sequester carbon in the soil and create fewer problems like runoff that can pollute waterways. “It’s good for the planet because you’re weaning food production off fossil fuels,” said Susan Chomba, member of the International Panel of Experts on Sustainable Food Systems, a think tank. AGENCIES

Blast kills at least 45 in Myanmar

BANGKOK: A blast on Sunday at a building in northeastern Myanmar said to have been storing explosives for mining has killed more than 45 people, according to rescue workers and independent media reports.

About 70 other people were injured in the explosion that took place around noon in the village of Kaung-tup, in Namhkam township. The area, located about 3 km south of the Chinese border, is under the control of the Taang National Liberation Army, an ethnic armed group which has engaged in sporadic fighting against Myanmar’s central government. A rescue worker who rushed to the site of the blast told The Associated Press that 46 bodies, including six children, had been recovered by Sunday evening and taken for cremation.

The rescuer, who spoke on condition of anonymity for security reasons, said 74 injured people had been transported to the township hospital and rescue operations were continuing. Another rescuer in Namhkam, who also spoke on condition of



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

anonymity, said about 40 people were killed and more than 100 houses near the blast site were damaged.

Myanmar media outlets, including Shan State’s online Shwe Phye Myay news agency, reported death tolls ranging from 50 to 55. They published photos and videos showing smoke from the explosion and damaged buildings and debris in its aftermath. Chinese state broadcaster CCTV reported the explosion caused multiple deaths and injuries, with many residential houses being severely damaged, but did not give figures. It said that accord-

ing to preliminary investigations, the blast occurred at a site where large quantities of explosives used for mining operations were stored. Local authorities are currently providing relief, medical care and resettlement assistance to affected residents, said the report.

The Taang National Liberation Army, or TNLA, said in a statement released on its Telegram channel that gelignite had been stored by the group’s economic department for use in mining and stone quarrying sites, and that an investigation into the cause of the explosion is underway. AGENCIES

Nicaraguan indigenous leader Brooklyn Rivera dies after 3 years in jail

WASHINGTON: Nicaraguan Indigenous leader and former lawmaker Brooklyn Rivera died on Saturday night in state custody at age 73, news outlets 100% Noticias and Confidential reported on Sunday, citing sources close to his family and at the hospital where Rivera had been staying.

The reports follow government confirmation last week that Rivera has been detained since 2023, after his family, the U.S. government and representatives of the United Nations demanded proof that he was still alive.

Rivera, a leader of the Miskito people who had been at odds with the ruling Sandinist government for decades, has been imprisoned since September 29, 2023, as part of a years-long crackdown on dissent. His family has said he is imprisoned for political reasons and that the government has not presented formal charges.

At least a handful of prisoners have died in the Nicaraguan government’s custody in recent years as the government has imprisoned hundreds of journalists, activists and political opposition.

The Nicaraguan government said in January that it would release some prisoners, following pressure on its government in the wake of the US military operation to capture Venezuela’s then-President Nicolás Maduro. AGENCIES

Palestinian man shot at West Bank barrier near Jerusalem

CAIRO: A Palestinian man was shot and killed by Israeli forces on Sunday at a concrete barrier separating the occupied West Bank from Jerusalem, the Palestinian Health Ministry said. The ministry identified him as 26-year-old Imad Haroun Ishtayeh from Salim town, east of Nablus. It said Israeli forces shot him in a thigh in al-Ram town, and he was pronounced dead at the Palestinian Medical Complex in Ramallah.

Footage circulating online showed people carrying his body and climbing down a ladder that had been placed against the wire-topped barrier, while traffic continued to roll by and a horn blared.

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Vijay Kumar Jain S/o Late Sh. Shikhar Chand Jain, aged about 58 years, R/o 87, 1st Floor, Bahubali Enclave, Delhi-110092 have changed my name from Vijay Kumar to Vijay Kumar Jain for all future purposes.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Sumit@Aju, S/o: Ram Chand, R/o: H.No. 1006, Gali No. 15, L Block, Sangam Vihar, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 394/2021, U/s: 379/411 IPC, Police Station Kashmere Gate, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Sumit@Aju cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Sumit@Aju has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Sumit@Aju of Police Station Kashmere Gate, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 30.06.2026.

By Order
Sh. Vaibhav Garg
JMFC-11, Central, 1st Floor, Room No. 138
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

US Southern Command announced the strike with its usual language that the vessel was “engaged in narco-trafficking operations” and operated by a designated terrorist organisation. It provided no evidence for the allegation.

An increasing number of Palestinians from the West Bank have tried to enter Israel illegally to work in recent years. Tens of thousands of Palestinians had held Israeli work permits, but access was sharply restricted after the attack by Hamas-led militants on southern Israel on October 7, 2023 sparked the war in Gaza.

Since then, unemployment in the West Bank has surged amid an economic slowdown. And around 50 workers have been killed by Israeli fire, with over 38,000 arrested though many were later released, the Palestinian official Wafa news agency reported Sunday. AGENCIES

US strike on alleged drug boat kills 3 people

It is a fourth attack this week

WASHINGTON: The US military said it carried out another strike Saturday on a boat accused of smuggling drugs in the eastern Pacific Ocean, killing three men in the fourth attack this week and putting the total death toll at 205.

US Southern Command announced the strike with its usual language that the vessel was “engaged in narco-trafficking operations” and operated by a designated terrorist organisation. It provided no evidence for the allegation.

It’s the latest in a monthslong campaign against alleged drug boats traversing the Caribbean Sea and eastern Pacific.

Video released by the military on social media shows a small vessel floating in the ocean before it’s hit and engulfed in a fireball. The attack brings the death toll to 205 in a series of US strikes that began in early September, with other attacks announced on Tuesday, Wednesday and Friday. AGENCIES

BEFORE DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL-II, DELHI
4TH FLOOR, JEEVAN TARA BUILDING, PARLIAMENT STREET, NEW DELHI- 110001

[Notice under section 19(4) of the Recovery of Debts Due to Bank and Financial Institutions Act, 1993 read with rule 12 & 13 of the Debts Recovery Tribunal (Procedure), Rules 1993] in the matter of

TA No. 208/2024 Date: 21.05.2026

ICICI BANK LIMITED ...APPLICANT

KHUSHBU NIGAM & ORS. ...RESPONDENT

To, Defendant
D1. Khushbu Nigam W/o Pankaj Srivastav
D2. Pankaj Srivastav S/o Heera Lal Srivastava
Both at RZ-232B, Sadh Nagar, Goli No. 6, Palam Colony, New Delhi-45
Also at Flat No. 10227, 10th Floor, Fiddle Wood Project, Mahagun Mywoods Phase-III, Plot No. GH-04 Sect 16-C, Greater Noida UP- 201307.
D3, M/s Mahagun India Pvt. Ltd, The Corenthum Tower-B, Office No. B-44, Plot No. A-41 Sect. 62, Noida- 201301.

Whereas the above-named applicant(s) has/have instituted a case for recovery of Rs. 31,56,843/- (Rupees Thirty One Lakh Fifty Six Thousand Eight Hundred Forty Three Only) against you and whereas it has been shown to the satisfaction of the Tribunal that it is not possible to serve you in ordinary way therefore, this notice is given by advertisement directing you to make appearance in the Tribunal on 30.09.2026 at 11:00 A.M.

Take notice that in default of your appearance on the day before the mentioned case will be heard and determined in your absence. All the matters will be taken up through Video Conferencing or physical and for that purpose:

(i) All the Advocates/Litigants shall download the "Cisco Webex" application/software;

(ii) Meeting ID and Password for the date next date of hearing qua cases to be taken by Hon'ble Presiding Officer/Registrar shall be displayed in the daily cause list itself at DRT Official Portal i.e. drt.gov.in;

(iii) In any exigency qua that, the Advocates/Litigants can contact the concerned official at Ph. No. 23748473.

Given under my hand and seal of the Tribunal this 21st Day of May, 2026.

By Order of The Tribunal
(Suraj Parkash)
Section Officer
DRT-II, Delhi

F.No. 1-9/2025-Skt.I
Government of India
Ministry of Education
Department of Higher Education

Dated: 25.05.2026

Advertisement No. 04/2026

Applications are invited for appointment to the post of Vice-Chancellor of Shri Lal Bahadur Shastri National Sanskrit University(SLSNSU), New Delhi.

The Vice-Chancellor, is the Academic as well as Administrative Head and is the Chief Executive Officer of the University. The eligibility conditions and otherwise for consideration to this post is as under. The candidates shall be:

- An eminent scholar in the field of Sanskrit and allied subjects and his qualifications shall be as specified in the regulations made under the University Grants Commission Act, 1956(3 of 1956).
- Preferably not more than 65 years of age as on the closing date of receipt of applications as prescribed in the advertisement.

Salary and Service Conditions:

- The post carries a pay of Rs. 2,10,000/-(Fixed) per month with Special Allowance of Rs. 11,250/- and other usual allowances.
- The other terms and conditions of the services will be those as set forth in the Central Sanskrit Universities Act, 2020 and Statutes of the University.

Procedure for appointment:

- Appointment will be made from a panel of three names recommended by a Search-cum-Selection-Committee constituted in accordance with the procedure laid down in Statutes of the University.

Submission of Application:

- The advertisement is available on the websites <http://www.education.gov.in> & <https://www.slsrsv.ac.in>.
- Candidates are required to "APPLY ONLINE ONLY" on the Ministry of Education SAMARTH portal as per the link given below: <https://vcrec.samarth.ac.in/index.php/>
- The Ministry will not be responsible for the delay in receipt of applications for whatever reasons it may be.
- The persons who are already in service should apply through proper channel and submit their applications through their employer along with the NOC/Vigilance Clearance Report given by the Chief Vigilance Officer of their Institutions/Departments along with the applications.
- Incomplete applications/applications received after the last date of receipt of applications will not be considered.
- The above link will be active from 1st June, 2026, 10:00 Hours to 30th June, 2026, 17:00 Hours.

-sd/-
(Dr. Saumya Rajan)
Deputy Secretary to the Government of India
Tel No: 23070182

cbc 21371/11/0003/2627

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING ATTENDANCE OF DEFENDANT

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./ 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Sumit@Aju, S/o: Ram Chand, R/o: H.No. 1006, Gali No. 15, L Block, Sangam Vihar, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 394/2021, U/s: 379/411 IPC, Police Station Kashmere Gate, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Sumit@Aju cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Sumit@Aju has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Sumit@Aju of Police Station Kashmere Gate, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 30.06.2026.

By Order
Sh. Vaibhav Garg
JMFC-11, Central, 1st Floor, Room No. 138
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/7208/N/2026

Adani says US legal issues behind it, bets on AI-driven infra boom

Adani Group Chairman said the conglomerate remained committed to expansion despite heightened scrutiny over the past year

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Billionaire Gautam Adani said the Adani Group has moved beyond its US legal challenges and is accelerating investments across energy, transport, logistics and digital infrastructure, positioning itself to benefit from rising demand for AI-led growth.

In his annual letter to shareholders, Adani said the conglomerate remained committed to expansion despite heightened scrutiny over the past year, adding that matters related to the group's US legal proceedings were now "behind us", allowing it to focus on its next phase of growth.

Adani described the group's recent Rs 24,930 crore rights issue in flagship firm Adani Enterprises as a vote of confidence from investors at a time when the conglomerate faced questions over governance and regulatory issues.

"Even though it was a year in which the world grew more fractured, complex energy security models returned to the centre of national strategy and technology became inseparable from sovereignty, Adani Group remained anchored to an unwavering belief - India's future cannot wait," he said.



Adani Group Chairman Gautam Adani

Adani described recent Rs 24,930 cr rights issue in Adani Enterprises as a vote of confidence from investors

"While others debated, the Group built, advancing its journey as the world's most integrated infrastructure platform - across energy, transport, logistics, utilities and industrial manufacturing."

And this progress did not come in calm conditions for the ports-to-energy conglomerate. "It came in the middle of extraordinary scrutiny. However, we did not bend. We did not pause," he said. "Because what we have always been defined by is: Not the noise that

Key Points

- » The chairman outlined a strategy centred on what he called two converging growth drivers - infrastructure and intelligence
- » The rapid adoption of AI will need massive investments in power generation, transmission networks, data centres & logistics infrastructure
- » Group invested over Rs 1.5 lakh crore in FY26, one of its largest annual capex programmes

surrounds us, but the strength of our response. Not the intensity of the challenge, but the clarity of our purpose. Not the criticism, but the nation-building we continue to believe in."

Adani also sought to draw a line under the legal and regulatory challenges that have weighed on the group since late 2024. "The matters related to our US legal proceedings are now behind us thereby allowing us to focus with renewed confidence and belief on the next phase of our growth," he said.

The Adani Group has faced scrutiny from US authorities over bribery allegations linked to its renewable energy business, charges the conglomerate has denied. While the US Securities Exchange Commission has reached a settlement with the Adnai Group on the issue, the US Department of Justice has moved to drop all charges against the founder and others.

The chairman outlined a strategy centred on what he called two converging growth drivers - infrastructure and intelligence - arguing that the rapid adoption of artificial intelligence will require massive investments in power generation, transmission networks, data centres and logistics infrastructure. "Before AI can think, energy must flow," Adani said, reiterating his view that future technological leadership will depend as much on physical infrastructure as on software and digital innovation.

The group said it invested more than Rs 1.5 lakh crore during fiscal 2025-26, one of its largest annual capital expenditure programmes, as it expanded renewable energy, transmission, ports, airports, data centres and manufacturing operations. Among key milestones, Adani Green added 5.1

gigawatts of renewable energy capacity during the year, taking its operational portfolio to more than 19 GW, while Adani New Industries commissioned a 5-MW green hydrogen pilot project.

Adani Energy Solutions increased its transmission order book to Rs 71,779 crore, while Adani Power continued work on a more than Rs 2 lakh crore expansion programme aimed at raising generation capacity to 42 GW by fiscal 2032.

The group also highlighted progress in digital infrastructure, including plans to build a 2-GW data centre platform by 2030 and a memorandum of understanding with Google for a large-scale data centre project in Visakhapatnam.

Adani Ports handled more than 500 million tonnes of cargo during the year, while the group's airport business commissioned the Navi Mumbai International Airport and a new terminal at Guwahati Airport.

Looking ahead, Adani said the group's biggest challenge was no longer access to capital but executing projects fast enough to meet India's infrastructure and energy needs, particularly as artificial intelligence drives demand for power-intensive digital infrastructure.

Domestic air traffic declines 4.2% to over 1.38 cr in April

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Domestic air traffic declined 4.2 per cent to little over 1.38 crore in April compared to March amid multiple headwinds, including relatively softer travel demand.

The latest data from aviation watchdog DGCA showed that carriers flew more than 1.38 crore passengers in April, 3.47 per cent lower than over 1.43 crore passengers carried in April last year.

The decline is 4.2 per cent compared to the traffic of 1.44 crore passengers recorded in March.

"Passengers carried by domestic airlines during January - April 2026 were 575.49 lakhs as against 575.13 lakhs during the corresponding period of the previous year thereby registering an annual growth of 0.06 per cent and monthly growth of -3.47 per cent," DGCA said in its report for the month of April.

Airlines have been facing multiple headwinds, including rising operational costs due to higher fuel prices and relatively slower demand.

Amid the challenging scenario, carriers have also temporarily trimmed their network.

The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) data showed that IndiGo's market share rose to 65 per cent in April from 63.3 per cent in March while that of Air India Group fell to 24.7 per cent from 26.2 per cent.

The market share of Akasa



'Domestic airlines carried 575.49 lakhs passengers during Jan-April 2026 against 575.13 lakhs in Jan-April 2025 thereby registering annual growth of 0.06%'

Air inched up to 5.8 per cent last from 5.4 per cent in March and that of SpiceJet declined to 3.4 per cent from 3.8 per cent during the same period.

In April, state-owned Alliance Air's share shrunk to 0.3 per cent from 0.6 per cent in March.

A total of 3,266 passenger-related complaints were received by scheduled domestic airlines in April and the number of complaints per 10,000 passengers carried for the month stood at 2.36, as per DGCA.

In terms of On-Time Per-

formance (OTP) in April, IndiGo topped the list at 88.5 per cent, followed by Air India Group (82.4 per cent), Akasa Air (81.4 per cent), Alliance Air (71.2 per cent) and SpiceJet (31.2 per cent).

OTP is computed for ten major airports -- Bangalore, Delhi, Hyderabad, Mumbai, Chennai, Kolkata, Ahmedabad, Cochin, Guwahati and Lucknow.

Last month, around 1.12 per cent of the flights were delayed by more than two hours.

According to DGCA data, over 1.35 lakh passengers were affected by flight delays and airlines shelled out little over Rs 2.41 crore towards facilitation whereas 77,065 passengers were impacted by flight cancellations and in this regard, carriers paid Rs 2.04 crore towards compensation and facilities.

A total of 641 passengers were denied boarding and the airlines shelled out Rs 57.65 lakh for compensation and facilities.

Coffee Day Global returns to profit, posts PAT of ₹14 cr in FY26



NEW DELHI: Coffee Day Global Ltd, the operator of popular café chain Café Coffee Day, reported a profit after tax (PAT) of Rs 14 crore in FY26, while its revenue from operations grew 5.7 per cent to Rs 1,094 crore.

The company's operating profit or EBITDA rose 27 per cent to Rs 198 crore in FY2025-26, according to an exchange filing by its parent entity, Coffee Day Enterprises Ltd (CDEL).

In FY25, Coffee Day Global had reported a net revenue of Rs 1,034.63 crore and a loss after tax of Rs 175.92 crore.

Coffee Day Global's Average Sales Per Day (ASPD) witnessed a marginal increase to Rs 21,101 in the financial year ended March 31, 2026, compared with Rs 21,016 in FY25.

Its parent company, Coffee Day Enterprises Ltd, also reported a profit after tax (PAT) of Rs 210.14 crore in FY26, compared with a loss of Rs 143.20 crore in the previous fiscal.

Revenue from operations of CDEL increased 2.55 per cent to Rs 1,154.40 crore in FY26. AGENCIES

Govt cuts windfall tax on export of petrol, diesel & aviation turbine fuel

The finance ministry in a notification said road & infrastructure cess will be nil on export of petrol and diesel

NEW DELHI: The government has halved windfall gains tax on export of petrol to Rs 1.5 litre, while reducing the levy on diesel to Rs 13.5/litre and aviation turbine fuel to Rs 9.5/litre effective June 1.

The finance ministry in a notification said road and infrastructure cess will be nil on export of petrol and diesel.

Also, there is no change in the existing duty rates on petrol and diesel cleared for domestic consumption.

The special additional excise duty (SAED) on petrol at Rs 3/litre was imposed on May 16 and the fortnightly review slashed it to Rs 1.5/litre from June 1.

The duty on export of diesel has been reduced to Rs 13.5 per litre, from Rs 16.5 per litre, and aviation turbine fuel to Rs 9.5 per litre, from Rs 16 per litre from June 1.

The government had on March 26 imposed an export duty of Rs 21.50 a litre on petrol, and Rs 29.5 a litre on ATF. In the review on April 11, the duties were hiked to Rs 55.5/litre and Rs 42/litre. In the April 30 review, they were cut to Rs 23/litre and Rs 33/litre, and further slashed to Rs 16.5/litre and Rs 16/litre on May 16.

The windfall tax was levied to increase domestic availability of the fuel amid the US-Israel crisis, the ministry said. PTI

It was also aimed at not allowing exporters to take undue advantage due to price differences as globally crude oil prices had risen since the beginning of the war.

On February 28, the United States and Israel launched military strikes against Iran, triggering sweeping retaliation from Tehran.

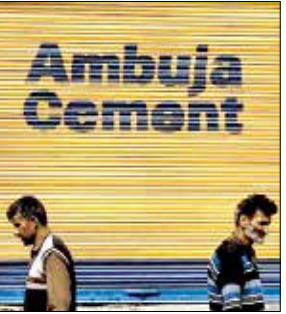
Crude oil prices have remained above \$100 per barrel over the past week, from the about \$73 per barrel before the war. The windfall tax was to ensure domestic availability of petroleum products by disincentivising exports against the backdrop of the West Asia crisis, the ministry said. PTI

Ex-Sanghi Industries promoter settles dispute with Ambuja Cements & withdraws NCLAT plea

NEW DELHI: Former Sanghi Industries promoter Alok Sanghi has withdrawn his appeal before the NCLAT against Ambuja Cements after reaching a settlement with the Adani Group-owned cement maker, bringing their dispute over an Rs 84-crore personal guarantee to an end.

The development follows Ambuja Cements' decision to withdraw its insolvency plea against Sanghi before the Ahmedabad bench of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) on April 10, 2026.

Sanghi had challenged an NCLT order passed in November 2025 that admitted Ambuja Cements' insolvency application against him in connection with



a personal guarantee of Rs 84 crore and appointed an interim resolution professional.

Earlier this year, NCLAT was informed that both parties had settled the matter, prompting Ambuja Cements to seek withdrawal of its application filed under Section 95 of the

Appellate tribunal was also told that report of resolution professional under Section 99 had not been filed due to a stay granted by NCLAT

Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC). The appellate tribunal was also told that the resolution professional's report under Section 99 had not been filed due to a stay granted by NCLAT.

On May 26, Sanghi's counsel sought permission to withdraw the appeal, which was

allowed by the tribunal. NCLAT recorded that the appeal stood dismissed as withdrawn.

The dispute stemmed from Ambuja's acquisition of Sanghi Industries in a Rs 5,185-crore deal completed in December 2023.

Ambuja had initiated insolvency proceedings against Sanghi as a personal guarantor after seeking recovery of Rs 84 crore linked to an unpaid electricity liability.

Sanghi had argued that the August 2023 share purchase agreement contained warranties and indemnities but did not include a personal guarantee. The settlement now closes the litigation between the two sides. AGENCIES

Suzlon Energy to challenge Sebi's ₹28.95 crore penalty order in SAT

NEW DELHI: Suzlon Energy Ltd said it will move the Securities Appellate Tribunal (SAT) against a Sebi order imposing penalty of Rs 28.95 crore on the company, its two promoters and ex-CFOs over alleged misrepresentation of financial statements.

In a BSE filing, the company stated that the Sebi, through an order passed on May 29, 2026, set aside an earlier adjudication ruling on June 27, 2025.

The earlier ruling had exonerated Suzlon Energy and its promoter-directors Vinod R Tanti, Girish R Tanti and former CFOs Kirti J Vagadi and Amit Agarwal without imposing any penalty regarding alle-



gations of misrepresentation in financial statements between FY14 and FY18.

"The company will be filing an appeal before the Securities Appellate Tribunal in respect of the SEBI order dated 29th May 2026," the renewable energy solutions provider said on Saturday.

Capital markets regulator

Sebi imposed a penalty of Rs 15.95 crore on Suzlon Energy Ltd (SEL), Rs 5.75 crore on Vinod R Tanti, and Rs 5.45 crore on Girish R Tanti.

The markets watchdog also penalised its former chief financial officers: Rs 1.5 crore on Kirti J Vagadi and Rs 30 lakh on Amit Agarwal.

Suzlon noted that after the adjudication order, Sebi issued a show-cause notice in September 2025, under its revisionary powers, seeking to examine whether the earlier order should be reviewed.

The company responded to the notice, providing factual justifications and denying the allegations. PTI

NLCIL, RIL plan to jointly develop lignite gasification in Gujarat

NLC India Ltd and Reliance Industries Ltd have signed a pact to evaluate underground lignite gasification

NEW DELHI: NLC India Ltd (NLCIL) and Reliance Industries Ltd (RIL) will jointly explore developing an underground lignite gasification project in Gujarat as part of efforts to augment domestic gasified fuel supplies amid the global fuel crunch, sources said.

The public sector undertaking has signed an agreement with RIL to assess the feasibility and technical viability of converting lignite reserves through underground gasification.

NLCIL holds two lignite blocks in Gujarat that would be considered for the project, they said. The preliminary tech-

nical studies for underground lignite gasification blocks with RIL are in progress, they said.

Reliance Industries was brought on board for its expertise in gasification technologies, sources said.

The move is aimed at partially addressing domestic gas shortage exacerbated by the ongoing global fuel crisis. If successful, the project could provide a supplementary source of synthesis gas for industrial use and potentially strengthen energy security by reducing dependence on imported liquefied natural gas (LNG).

NLCIL, a state-run miner

CLOSER LOOK

- » NLCIL holds two lignite blocks in Gujarat that would be considered for the project, sources said
- » The preliminary technical studies for underground lignite gasification blocks with RIL are in progress, they said
- » Reliance Industries was brought on board for its expertise in gasification technologies, sources said

and power producer, has been seeking alternative ways to monetise its lignite resources. Underground lignite gasification converts in-situ lignite into synthesis gas (a mixture of hydrogen, carbon monoxide and other gases) which can

be used as fuel or as a feed-stock in chemical and fertiliser industries.

A senior industry analyst said the partnership with Reliance Industries, which has prior experience in gasification projects and downstream gas han-

dling, could accelerate project development and de-risk technical challenges.

The company is also planning to set up a lignite-to-methanol plant estimated at Rs 4,394 crore, at Neyveli, in Tamil Nadu which is likely to be completed by next year. The project is part of NLCIL's diversification plan.

The proposed lignite-to-methanol plant is in line with the Centre's coal gasification plan, a sustainable way of utilising the fuel to meet its ambitious net-zero plans.

The Union Cabinet approved a Rs 37,500-crore scheme this month to promote

surface coal and lignite gasification projects, aiming to gasify around 75 million tonnes of coal. The scheme is intended to accelerate India's coal and lignite gasification programme and support the national target of gasifying 100 million tonnes of coal by 2030.

The scheme marks a major step towards strengthening energy security and reducing dependence on imports of key products such as LNG (more than 50 per cent imported), urea (20 per cent imported), ammonia (100 per cent imported), and methanol (80-90 per cent imported). PTI

CLEANLINESS DRIVE



POWERGRID is observing Swachhata Pakhwada in its offices spread across the country to maintain a clean and healthy environment. As part of the observance, POWERGRID employees took the Swachhata Pledge. A Swachhata cleanliness drive was also conducted around office premises and vicinity, to maintain a clean and healthy environment in presence of Vamsi Rama Mohan Burra, CMD, G Ravisankar, Director (Finance), Dr. Yatindra Dwivedi, Director (Personnel), Naveen Srivastava, Director (Operations), and senior officials at Corporate Centre, Gurugram. Nukkad Natak was also organised to raise public awareness about cleanliness. MPOST

India, US chief negotiators to hold four-day trade talks from today

US team will be led by its chief negotiator Brendan Lynch. India's chief negotiator is Darpan Jain, additional secretary in Dept of Commerce

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The chief negotiators of the US and India will begin four-day talks here on Monday on finalising the details of the interim trade pact, whose framework was agreed upon in February.

The US team will be led by its chief negotiator Brendan Lynch. India's chief negotiator is Darpan Jain, who is an additional secretary in the Department of Commerce.

The two sides are "proposed to finalise the details of the interim agreement and take forward the negotiations under the broader BTA on multiple areas such as market access, non-tariff measures, customs and trade facilitation, investment promotion, and economic security alignment," the commerce ministry has said.

On February 7, India and the US issued a joint statement finalising the contours or framework of the first phase of the bilateral trade agreement (BTA) or an interim trade agreement. Now, both sides will have to finalise the legal text for that deal.

The framework reaffirmed the countries' commitment to the broader India-US BTA negotiations. According to that



On February 7, India and the US issued a joint statement finalising the contours or framework of the first phase of BTA or an interim trade agreement

framework, the US had agreed to reduce tariffs on India to 18 per cent from 50 per cent. It had removed the 25 per cent tariffs on Indian goods for buying Russian oil and was to cut the remaining 25 per cent to 18 per cent under the pact.

But, on February 20 this year, the US Supreme Court ruled against President Donald Trump's sweeping reciprocal tariffs, which were imposed under the 1977 International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA).

After that, the US Presi-

dent announced the imposition of 10 per cent tariffs on all countries for 150 days, starting February 24. In light of these changes, a meeting between the chief negotiators of India and the US scheduled for February was postponed. The two sides then met in Washington in April, when the Indian team, headed by Jain, visited America from April 20-23, 2026.

To carry forward those discussions, the US team is visiting India from 1-4th June.

As the tariff landscape has changed in the US, both sides

Highlights

- » As the tariff landscape has changed in the US, both sides may wish to revisit the agreement's framework
- » Under agreed framework, India proposed to eliminate or reduce tariffs on all US industrial goods & a wide range of US food & agricultural products
- » Now, with all US trading partners facing a uniform 10% tariff, pact requires recalibration

may wish to revisit the agreement's framework.

Under the agreed framework, India proposed to eliminate or reduce tariffs on all US industrial goods and a wide range of US food and agricultural products, including dried distillers' grains (DDGs), red sorghum for animal feed, tree nuts, fresh and processed fruit, soybean oil, wine and spirits, and additional products.

New Delhi has also expressed its intentions to purchase \$500 billion of US energy products, aircraft and aircraft

parts, precious metals, technology products, and coking coal over the next five years.

This meeting will be important, as India enjoys a comparative advantage over its competitor countries. Now, with all US trading partners facing a uniform 10 per cent tariff, the pact requires recalibration.

Further, in March, the US Trade Representative (USTR) also launched two unilateral Section 301 investigations against a number of countries, including India, over excess capacity and failures to eradicate forced labour in global supply chains.

India has strongly rejected allegations made by the US Trade Representative in those two investigations and has requested that the probes be initiated, as the initiation notice has failed to provide a cogent rationale to substantiate the claims.

The US was the second-largest trading partner of India in 2025-26. India's outbound shipments to the US grew marginally 0.92 per cent to \$87.3 billion during the last fiscal year, while imports increased 15.95 per cent to \$52.9 billion. The trade surplus declined to \$34.4 billion in 2025-26 from \$40.89 billion in 2024-25.

RBI likely to maintain status quo on rates in monetary policy meet

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank is expected to leave the key policy rate unchanged at 5.25 per cent this week and adopt a cautious stance that factors in the possible headwinds to inflation and growth trajectory amid the West Asia turmoil, experts opined.

With surging energy prices, continuing supply chain woes and a depreciating rupee, primarily driven by external challenges, some experts are of the view that the RBI may raise its inflation forecast and lower its GDP growth estimate at its bi-monthly monetary policy meet from June 3 to 5.

After three days of deliberations, the six-member Monetary Policy Committee (MPC), headed by RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra, will announce its decision on June 5.

In April, the Reserve Bank had kept its key policy rate unchanged, adopting a cautious wait-and-watch stance as policymakers assessed the fallout from the West Asia conflict on energy supplies, inflation and growth.

A research report from the SBI's economic research department expects the RBI to maintain status quo in June policy against volatile backdrop.

Going by the growth-inflation spiral, the report expects the consumer price index (CPI) trajectory (as of now) may indicate more than 5 per cent inflation for the next three quarters (current quarter at 4 to 4.1 per cent).

It also expects Q4FY26 real



SBI's economic research dept expects Q4FY26 real GDP growth closer to 7.2% and FY26 GDP growth at 7.5%

GDP growth closer to 7.2 per cent and FY26 GDP growth at 7.5 per cent.

"Our nowcasted full year FY2027 GDP growth rate of 6.6 per cent, however, with the continued geopolitical uncertainties, the numbers will be revised as more data comes in.

"Our call is along 'hold the rates' with a data-driven future dependency. However, an inflation targeting central bank can always use interest rate tools like Operation Twist that address market microstructure," the report said.

It also emphasised that the MPC needs to debate the role of exchange rate as a policy anchor beyond its mandate of pure inflation targeting.

Madan Sabnavis, Chief Economist at Bank of Baroda, also does not expect any change in the repo rate or stance next

week.

"However, the tone will be cautious, leaning towards being hawkish. We can expect RBI to increase their inflation forecast towards 5 per cent and lower that on GDP more towards 6.5 per cent from 6.9 per cent," he said.

Sabnavis also does not expect any specific foreign exchange measures, though there will be an explanation of developments.

In its annual report released on Friday, the RBI said it will be reviewing and improving GDP growth and inflation forecasting during the current financial year. RBI said that the outlook for the Indian economy in 2026-27 remains positive, supported by strong macroeconomic fundamentals, although a prolonged West Asia conflict may pose downside risk.

According to the report, inflation in 2026-27 is likely to remain aligned with the target on the back of adequate foodgrain stocks, sufficient reservoir levels and stable agricultural prospects despite possible El Nino conditions and above-normal summer temperatures.

However, the evolving upside risks to inflation may emanate from multiple other factors such as a spike in global fuel and commodity prices amid geopolitical tensions, it added.

The government has set the consumer price index (CPI) based headline inflation target at 4 per cent with the upper tolerance level of 6 per cent and the lower tolerance level of 2 per cent for the central bank.

Canadian & Indian officials express optimism over negotiations for free trade agreement

TORONTO: Canadian and Indian officials have expressed optimism about ongoing negotiations on a proposed free trade agreement during a business summit in Regina, amid renewed engagement between the two countries after trade talks stalled in 2023, according to media reports.

Saskatchewan Premier Scott Moe, Canada's High Commissioner to India Chris Cooter and India's High Commissioner to Canada Dinesh Patnaik, on Friday, participated in the Western Canada-India Leaders Summit in Regina, capital city of the Saskatchewan province, where they discussed bilateral ties and negotiations on the proposed Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA), and spoke with delegations.

According to Canadian broadcaster CBC News, Cooter



said negotiations on the agreement were continuing and expressed confidence that a deal could be reached later this year. "The free trade agreement will happen. I have no doubt" CBC also reported that Patnaik said negotiations were ongoing.

Moe described the relationship between Saskatchewan and India as important for the province and pointed to ongoing trade discussions as a reason for optimism, according to CBC.

The comments came days after India's Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush

Goyal said the two countries were looking to conclude negotiations on a free trade agreement before the end of this year, and the prime ministers of both sides had tasked officials with completing the agreement and expanding bilateral trade from about \$17 billion to \$50 billion by 2030.

Trade negotiations between India and Canada stalled in 2023 after relations deteriorated following Canadian allegations linking Indian agents to the killing of Sikh separatist Hardeep Singh Nijjar in British Columbia. India rejected the allegations as "absurd" and "motivated".

Recent months have seen renewed trade engagement between the two countries. During his visit to Canada earlier this week, Goyal said Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney's

recent visit to India had "completely changed" the way the two countries viewed each other and had set the stage for a broader reset in ties. CBC reported that Moe credited Carney with helping restart engagement with India, including through a visit to Mumbai and New Delhi earlier this year, which Moe also attended.

The summit discussion also touched on trade in agricultural commodities. According to CBC News and Global News, Moe said he hoped pulse crops would be included in any future trade agreement but indicated their exclusion would not be a deal-breaker.

Global News reported that Moe said Saskatchewan could work around existing Indian duties on pulse imports even if those tariffs were not removed under a future agreement. PTI

Assam semiconductor plant likely to start production in FY27: Vaishnaw

NEW DELHI: The semiconductor plant at Jajiroad in Assam is expected to start production within this financial year, I&B and Electronics and IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw has said. Vaishnaw said this after his meeting with Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Saturday evening.

"Met Assam CM, @himantabiswa Ji. Discussed the progress of the semiconductor plant at Jajiroad. We aim to start production from this plant within this financial year," Vaishnaw said in a post on social media platform X.

The union minister said the National Institute of Electronics & Information Technology (NIELIT) for training young citizens in semiconductor manufacturing technologies is also shaping well.

The Assam chief minister



I&B and Electronics and IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw

said it was always a pleasure to meet the "erudite" and very knowledgeable" union minister.

"We exchanged notes on expanding the overall railway network and rail infrastructure in Assam - which includes work on ongoing 1,300+ km of track expansion and 50+ Amrit Bharat stations," Sarma said.

The Tata Semiconductor Assembly and Test Pvt Ltd (TSAT) at Jajiroad in Assam is set to become one of the coun-

try's premier manufacturing sites, aligns with the nation's broader goal of establishing a self-sufficient semiconductor ecosystem.

With an investment of Rs 27,000 crore, the Jajiroad facility is expected to produce up to 48 million semiconductor chips per day, employing advanced packaging technologies such as flip-chip and Integrated System in Package (ISIP).

This facility is designed to cater to essential sectors such as automotive, electric vehicles, telecommunications, and consumer electronics.

The unit goes beyond technological development as it brings significant socio-economic benefits by generating 15,000 direct and 11,000-13,000 indirect jobs, contributing to regional economic growth in Assam and nearby areas. PTI

FSSAI seeks Blinkit's reply on complaint over sale of bad curd

NEW DELHI: Food regulator FSSAI has sought explanation from quick commerce firm Blinkit on a complaint by a person who allegedly fell sick after consuming curd ordered from the platform, sources said.

FSSAI has received a written complaint from a person who allegedly had to seek medical help after falling sick following the consumption of curd bought from e-commerce platform Blinkit, they added. Medical prescription has also been attached in the complaint registered with FSSAI.

According to sources, FSSAI has written a letter on May 29 to the CEO of Blink Commerce Pvt Ltd), apart from person in-charge of operations after it received a complaint from a person who had ordered curd through the Blinkit mobile application.

The complainant allegedly developed severe stomach ache and diarrhoea shortly after consumption of the curd and had to seek medical help, they added.

Of late, FSSAI has received several complaints, either through social media or representations, regarding supply of unhygienic, spoiled or damaged food by sellers through the Blinkit E-commerce platform, sources said. The FSSAI has directed Blinkit to provide an explanation & also submit a comprehensive Action Taken Report. PTI

Top-7 cos lose ₹1.54L cr in mcap

NEW DELHI: The combined market valuation of seven of the top 10 valued firms eroded by Rs 1.54 lakh crore last week, with Reliance Industries taking the biggest hit.

In a holiday-shortened last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex dropped 639.61 points, or 0.84 per cent, and the NSE Nifty declined 171.55 points, or 0.72 per cent.

From the top 10 pack, Reliance Industries, HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel, ICICI Bank, Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), Bajaj Finance and Hindustan Unilever faced erosion in their valuations, while State Bank of India, Larsen & Toubro and Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) were the gainers.

The market valuation of Reliance Industries dropped



by Rs 46,078.3 crore to Rs 17,87,039.40 crore.

HDFC Bank's valuation eroded by Rs 33,333.06 crore to Rs 11,46,641.84 crore.

The valuation of Bharti Airtel tumbled Rs 25,408.96 crore to Rs 11,14,886.53 crore and that of TCS dived Rs 22,920.58 crore to Rs 8,15,480.75 crore.

The market capitalisation (mcap) of Hindustan Unilever diminished by Rs 13,169.46

crore to Rs 5,04,210.54 crore.

Bajaj Finance's valuation declined by Rs 7,253.24 crore to Rs 5,63,262.33 crore and that of ICICI Bank dipped by Rs 6,311.41 crore to Rs 9,00,589.91 crore.

However, the mcap of Larsen & Toubro jumped Rs 20,608.43 crore to Rs 5,60,836.64 crore.

State Bank of India's mcap climbed Rs 13,753.62 crore to Rs 8,89,831.54 crore and that of LIC went up by Rs 6,040.37 crore to Rs 5,20,484.06 crore.

Reliance Industries remained the most valued domestic firm followed by HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel, ICICI Bank, State Bank of India, TCS, Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro, LIC and Hindustan Unilever. PTI

US-Iran talks, oil prices and RBI's interest rate decision key drivers for mkts this week: Analysts

NEW DELHI: Developments around the US-Iran situation, crude oil prices, and the RBI's interest rate decision would determine the trend in the equity market in an event-heavy week ahead, analysts said.

Besides, macroeconomic data announcements, trading activity of foreign investors and the rupee-dollar trend would act as key drivers for equities, they noted.

"Participants will closely monitor global developments surrounding the US-Iran situation and movement in crude oil prices, which continue to remain critical for inflation expectations, currency stability, and foreign flows," Ajit



Mishra - SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

The final HSBC Manufacturing PMI reading for May will be announced on Monday, followed by the Services PMI and Composite PMI data on Wednesday. These indicators will provide important insights into demand trends, business activity, and growth resilience across sectors, he said.

"The key event of the week will be the RBI monetary policy announcement on Friday," Mishra added.

Additionally, investors will monitor India's GDP growth data and foreign exchange reserves figures for further clarity on economic momentum and external sector stability, he said.

"Markets are expected to remain highly sensitive to geopolitical and macroeconomic developments this week, with investor attention firmly focused on the evolving US-Iran negotiations, broader diplomatic developments in the Middle East and the trajectory of crude oil prices," Ponnudi R, CEO - Enrich Money, an

online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

Beyond geopolitics, investors are also expected to closely monitor rupee movement, institutional flow dynamics, global equity market trends and key macroeconomic indicators for further direction, he added.

Santosh Meena, Head of Research at Swastika Investment Ltd, said, "The primary domestic event will be the RBI monetary policy meeting, with the announcement scheduled for Friday. Market participants will closely monitor the RBI's stance on inflation, liquidity, and interest rates amid rising inflationary concerns and currency-related developments." PTI

LIC eying fintech foray, strategic investments, says CEO

LIC's CEO & MD R Doraiswamy said, it was one of the early adopters of digital technologies

NEW DELHI: State-owned insurer Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) is exploring the possibility of setting up a fintech arm, either through strategic investments or organically, as part of efforts to strengthen its digital capabilities and drive innovation, CEO & MD R Doraiswamy said.

Doraiswamy said LIC is actively engaging with fintech and insurtech firms to modernise operations and develop innovative solutions. As a large financial institution with investments across sectors, LIC is also evaluating strategic investments in specialised players to enhance

CLOSER LOOK

- » LIC is actively engaging with fintech and insurtech firms to modernise operations & develop innovative solutions'
- » LIC is also evaluating strategic investments in specialised players to enhance returns on policyholders' funds
- » Doraiswamy said LIC announced a 1:1 bonus issue and a dividend significantly higher than the previous year

returns on policyholders' funds.

He noted that LIC has long been an early adopter of digital technologies and has built strong in-house software development capabilities. However, the insurer continues to work closely with IT service provid-

ers for new infrastructure and platforms, combining internal expertise with external support.

According to Doraiswamy, LIC is assessing multiple options, including partnerships with fintech firms, as it seeks to modernise applications

and remain agile in an increasingly competitive market. The insurer is currently evaluating the value proposition of various alternatives.

On the government's plans to dilute its stake further, he said LIC has been prepared since its 2022 IPO and would work closely with the Centre whenever a decision on the timing and size of the stake sale is taken. The government raised about Rs 21,000 crore by selling a 3.5 per cent stake in LIC through its IPO in 2022. Before the listing, LIC was wholly owned by the government. He said the Centre remains com-

mitted to meeting minimum public shareholding requirements but is awaiting favourable market conditions before launching another public offer.

Highlighting shareholder rewards, Doraiswamy said LIC announced a 1:1 bonus issue and a dividend significantly higher than the previous year. The board has recommended a final dividend of Rs 10/share for FY26, subject to shareholder approval. Earlier this month, LIC reported a 23% rise in Q4 net profit to Rs 23,420 crore, the highest quarterly profit posted by any financial services firm in the country. AGENCIES

NEW DELHI: The primary market is set for limited activity next week with two companies — CMR Green Technologies and Hexagon Nutrition — launching initial public offerings (IPOs) worth nearly Rs 770 crore combined.

Both issues are entirely offer-for-sale (OFS), meaning the companies will not receive any proceeds, with the funds going to existing shareholders.

The Rs 630.62-crore IPO of CMR Green Technologies, a non-ferrous metal recycler, will open for subscription from June 3-5, with anchor bidding scheduled for June 2.

The company has fixed a price band of Rs 182-192 per share.

The issue comprises the sale of up to 3.28 crore equity shares by promoters and an investor shareholder. Market experts said the IPO's grey market premium has remained firm at Rs 25-30 per share in recent sessions.

Faridabad-based CMR Green manufactures aluminium and zinc alloys and processes scrap metals.

It operates 13 recycling facilities across India and supplies automotive OEMs and Tier-1 vendors, includ-

ing Honda Cars India, Bajaj Auto, Hero MotoCorp, Royal Enfield, Endurance Technologies, Rockman Industries and Craftsman Automation.

Meanwhile, Hexagon Nutrition's Rs 139-crore IPO will open on June 5 and close on June 9, with anchor bidding on June 4. The company has set a price band of Rs 42-45 per share.

The issue involves the sale of more than 3.08 crore shares by promoters. CMR Green shares are expected to list on June 10, while Hexagon Nutrition is likely to debut on June 12. AGENCIES

SINGAPORE OPEN

Satwik-Chirag end title drought

The Asian Games and Commonwealth Games champions produced a gritty comeback to secure their first title in two years

SINGAPORE: Former world No. 1 pair Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty fought back from a game down to clinch their maiden Singapore Open title, defeating Indonesia's Fajar Alfian and Muhammad Shohibul Fikri in the men's doubles final of the BWF Super 750 tournament, here on Sunday.

The Asian Games and Commonwealth Games champions produced a gritty comeback to secure their first title in two years and their ninth career World Tour crown, besides claiming a third Super 750 title with a tense 18-21, 21-17, 21-16 win in one hour 13 minutes.

The victory was particularly significant for the world No. 4 duo, who became the first Indians to win the doubles title at the Singapore Open.

Satwik and Chirag had last lifted a trophy at the Thailand Open in 2024. Since then, they had reached four finals but finished runners-up on each occasion before finally breaking the drought in Singapore.

The Indians had entered the final trailing 1-2 in their head-to-head record against the Indonesian pair, with their most recent defeat coming in the Malaysia Open quarterfinals in January.



Chirag Shetty, (left), and Satwiksairaj Rankireddy in action

PTI

After dropping a closely-fought opening game, Satwik and Chirag raised their intensity and dominated the longer rallies to turn the contest around against the world No. 3 Indonesians. The triumph capped an impressive week for the Indian pair, who had stunned reigning world champions and top seeds Kim Won Ho and Seo Seung Jae of South Korea in the semifinals.

As the winning point was sealed, Satwik lay flat on the court in celebration. Satwik followed it up with a baby-themed celebration, while an ecstatic Chirag removed his shirt and let out a loud roar before leaping onto his partner. "I think it's been a while since I've shown my body... I have really put in a lot of effort in the gym to make it good. Finally, all the viewers in the

stadium and back home, across the world, saw it. So I hope they were happy," Chirag said in a lighter vein.

"But jokes aside, two years... We knew for a fact that eventually the win will come. We had that belief and it was just a matter of time and finally we got it."

The duo later danced on court as they savoured a long-awaited return to the top step of the podium.

AGENCIES

Highlights

- » The victory was particularly significant for the world No. 4 duo
- » Satwik and Chirag had last lifted a trophy at the Thailand Open in 2024
- » The Indians had entered the final trailing 1-2 in their head-to-head record against Indonesian pair

Swiatek out of French Open

PARIS: There will be a first-time women's champion at Roland-Garros this year, and the odds are stacked in Marta Kostyuk's favor.

Undefeated this season on clay, the 15th-seeded Ukrainian player reached the quarterfinals at the French Open for the first time on Sunday by taking out four-time champion Iga Swiatek 7-5, 6-1 and ruining her birthday.

None of the players still in the draw have yet lifted the trophy in Paris, following Coco Gauff's elimination on Saturday and Swiatek's exit.

It's the same in the men's draw, after the defeats of Jan-nik Sinner and Novak Djokovic and with Carlos Alcaraz absent because of an injury.



Iga Swiatek of Poland in action

Kostyuk had lost her three previous matches against Swiatek and never taken a set against the former top-ranked player, who turned 25 on

Sunday. "I'm still in shock. To beat such an unbelievable player, who won four times here," she said.

AGENCIES

SUMMER SPECIAL TRAINS-2026

For the convenience of rail passengers during this summer season, Northern Railway is operating Summer Special Trains. The details are as under:-

Train No.	Station From	Dep. Time	Station To	Arr. Time	Date of Run
01492	Hazrat Nizamuddin	21:25	Pune Jn.	23:55	Upto 11.07.2026
01706	Ayodhya Dham	13:30	Jabalpur	06:45	Upto 15.07.2026
02398	Anand Vihar (T.)	13:30	Sheikpura	14:45	Upto 13.07.2026
02564	New Delhi	17:55	Barauni Jn.	15:10	Upto 15.07.2026
02570	New Delhi	12:15	Darbhanga Jn.	10:00	Upto 15.07.2026
02878	Anand Vihar (T.)	19:30	Ranchi	19:10	Upto 28.06.2026
03010	Anand Vihar (T.)	15:00	Dankuni	23:30	Upto 28.06.2026
03258	Anand Vihar (T.)	05:00	Danapur	20:45	Upto 13.07.2026
03294	New Delhi	14:15	Patna Jn.	12:25	Upto 16.07.2026
03310	Delhi Jn.	11:45	Dhanbad Jn.	13:00	Upto 12.07.2026
03312	Chandigarh	05:40	Dhanbad Jn.	11:00	Upto 14.07.2026
03436	Anand Vihar (T.)	14:50	Malda Town	22:30	Upto 30.06.2026
03640	Shakurbasti	21:10	Dhanbad Jn.	23:45	Upto 14.07.2026
03698	Anand Vihar (T.)	13:30	Sheikpura	14:45	Upto 15.07.2026
04002	Hazrat Nizamuddin	23:45	Dadar	22:40	Upto 14.07.2026
04008	Anand Vihar (T.)	08:30	Jogbani	15:00	Upto 11.07.2026
04010	Delhi Jn.	23:05	Sitamahi	23:30	Upto 09.07.2026
04014	Anand Vihar (T.)	15:40	Laukaha Bazar	20:15	Upto 15.07.2026
04028	Anand Vihar (T.)	09:15	Muzaffarpur Jn.	04:30	Upto 12.06.2026
04030	Anand Vihar (T.)	09:00	Muzaffarpur Jn.	04:30	Upto 15.07.2026
04052	New Delhi	18:15	Howrah Jn.	23:40	Upto 10.07.2026
04062	Delhi Jn.	11:45	Bhagalpur	13:30	Upto 14.07.2026
04064	New Delhi	11:00	Gaya Jn.	07:15	Upto 13.07.2026
04066	Anand Vihar (T.)	00:30	Khurda Road Jn.	11:30	Upto 08.06.2026
04070	Anand Vihar (T.)	00:20	Sheikpura	23:30	Upto 14.07.2026
04072	New Delhi	21:35	Supaul	06:35	Upto 15.07.2026
04081	New Delhi	23:45	Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Katra	12:00	Upto 15.07.2026
04082	Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Katra	21:00	New Delhi	10:00	Upto 16.07.2026
04088	New Delhi	15:50	Danapur	12:45	Upto 15.07.2026
04124	Hazrat Nizamuddin	15:45	Prayagraj Jn.	09:10	Upto 29.06.2026
04203	Lucknow	08:05	New Delhi	18:30	Upto 13.07.2026
04204	New Delhi	20:20	Lucknow	06:35	Upto 13.07.2026
04209	Varanasi	22:15	Delhi Jn.	13:30	Upto 15.07.2026
04210	Delhi Jn.	19:25	Varanasi	09:50	Upto 16.07.2026
04212	Sultanpur	04:00	Lok Manye Tilak(T.)	12:20	Upto 15.07.2026
04213	Ayodhya Cantt.	18:20	Anand Vihar (T.)	06:00	Upto 12.07.2026
04214	Anand Vihar (T.)	09:00	Ayodhya Cantt.	22:00	Upto 13.07.2026
04216	Sultanpur	04:00	Sabarmati BG	07:20	Upto 12.07.2026
04226	Varanasi	01:35	Lok Manye Tilak(T.)	12:20	Upto 09.07.2026
04227	Varanasi	11:05	Chandigarh	04:20	Upto 12.07.2026
04228	Chandigarh	06:00	Varanasi	00:55	Upto 13.07.2026
04312	Yog Nagari Rishikesh	22:20	Kolkata	08:00	Upto 10.07.2026
04314	Yog Nagari Rishikesh	15:20	Muzaffarpur Jn.	11:20	Upto 12.07.2026
04316	Yog Nagari Rishikesh	15:20	Gorakhpur	06:20	Upto 14.07.2026
04512	Chandigarh	23:35	Patna Jn.	21:15	Upto 09.07.2026
04519	Varanasi	20:40	Bathinda Jn.	17:00	Upto 16.07.2026
04520	Bathinda Jn.	20:50	Varanasi	17:30	Upto 15.07.2026
04610	Amritsar	20:10	Barauni Jn.	02:10	Upto 12.07.2026
04616	Firozpur Cantt.	12:00	Patna Jn.	18:35	Upto 14.07.2026
04624	Amritsar	20:10	Kolkata	15:00	Upto 29.06.2026
04652	Amritsar	10:55	Jaynagar	20:00	Upto 15.07.2026
04812	Haridwar Jn.	05:15	Barmer	07:30	Upto 17.07.2026
05058	Delhi Jn.	14:00	Gorakhpur	06:25	Upto 15.07.2026
05102	New Delhi	09:45	Gorakhpur	01:00	Upto 12.07.2026
05194	Pathankot	00:30	Chhapra	09:15	Upto 15.07.2026
05220	Anand Vihar (T.)	12:00	Muzaffarpur Jn.	09:45	Upto 11.07.2026
05302	Ambala Cantt.	01:40	Mau Jn.	23:00	Upto 17.07.2026
05576	Anand Vihar (T.)	05:15	Saharsa Jn.	09:05	Upto 16.07.2026
05580	Anand Vihar (T.)	05:15	Purnia Court	11:30	Upto 14.07.2026
06598	Yog Nagari Rishikesh	17:55	Yesvantpur Jn.	19:45	Upto 11.07.2026
07364	Yog Nagari Rishikesh	06:15	SSS Hubballi Jn.	06:30	Upto 02.07.2026
08744	Haridwar Jn.	18:55	Durg	03:00	Upto 29.06.2026
09094	Ayodhya Cantt.	14:45	Udhna Jn.	17:15	Upto 01.08.2026
09098	Ayodhya Cantt.	13:30	Udhna Jn.	17:30	Upto 29.07.2026
09258	Shakurbasti	13:15	Bhavnagar(T.)	08:50	Upto 27.06.2026
09272	Haridwar Jn.	16:25	Bhavnagar(T.)	04:35	On 01.06.2026
09310	Hazrat Nizamuddin	08:20	Indore Jn.	21:00	Upto 29.06.2026
09426	Haridwar Jn.	21:30	Sabarmati BG	22:30	Upto 30.06.2026
09524	Shakurbasti	13:15	Okha	13:00	Upto 01.07.2026
09610	Yog Nagari Rishikesh	17:55	Udaipur City	15:30	Upto 01.07.2026

For detailed information regarding stoppages and timings of above trains, please call RailMadad Helpline No. 139 or may visit enquiry website www.enquiry.indianrail.gov.in

Visit RailMadad website
www.railmadad.indianrailways.gov.in
Download RailMadad App.

RailMadad
Helpline No.
139

Please
Join us on



NORTHERN RAILWAY
Your Convenience-Our Concern
Visit us at: www.nr.indianrailways.gov.in
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PSG win back-to-back Champions League titles after shootout victory against Arsenal

BUDAPES: Winning the Champions League was so nice, Paris Saint-Germain had to do it twice.

PSG became back-to-back European champion by beating Arsenal 4-3 on penalties in a dramatic final in Budapest that ended 1-1 after extra time on Saturday.

"It's incredible," captain Marquinhos said. "From the very first day of this season, the coach said it's hard to win, and winning twice is even more difficult. So we all had to get back to work. That was the mentality."

Arsenal defender Gabriel Magalhaes fired the last of his team's penalties over the bar to hand PSG the shootout win.

The French giant is only the second team to retain the tro-



PSG's head coach Luis Enrique lift the trophy celebrating after winning the Champions League final football match

AP/PTI

phy in the modern era after all-time king of Europe Real Madrid.

Luis Enrique became a three-time winner as a coach and has moulded a team that

is simply too good even for the best the continent has to offer. That includes an Arsenal team that won the Premier League last week and topped the first stage of the Champions League

“ARSENAL DEFENDER GABRIEL MAGALHAES FIRED THE LAST OF HIS TEAM'S PENALTIES OVER THE BAR TO HAND PSG THE SHOOTOUT WIN”

with a perfect winning record, finishing 10 points and 10 places ahead of PSG.

That mattered little in Pus-kas Arena as PSG reaffirmed its status as the dominant force in European soccer.

"It's even more special because we knew before the match how difficult it would be," Luis Enrique said.

AGENCIES

Ishan Kishan named in Jharkhand T20 League squad

JAMSHEDPUR: India wicketkeeper-batter Ishan Kishan has been named in the Santhal Strikers squad for the Jharkhand T20 League but his availability remains doubtful for the tournament starting here on June 10.

India will take on Afghanistan in a three-match ODI series starting on June 13 in Dharamsala and Kishan has been named in the squad as Rishabh Pant was dropped. It remains to be seen if Kishan, who is also among those who have scored double tons in one-day cricket, is available for his state T20 league starting on June 13.

The other two ODIs will be played on June 17 and 20 at Lucknow and Chennai. Robin Minz, who played in a couple of matches for Mumbai Indians in the Indian Premier League, bagged an amount of Rs 15.25 lakh, while Virat Singh was picked up by Chota Nagpur Royals for Rs 13 lakh.

Sushant Mishra, who also played two matches for Rajasthan Royals this year, was roped in by Dhanbad Diamonds as franchises used their Rs 50 lakh purse each to build their squads.

The other teams in the league are Jamshed-pur Steelers, Koylanchal Super Kings, and Ranchi Titans.

AGENCIES

GLORY

Dubai-based Indian banker Shradha Gupta conquers Mount Everest

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Indian mountaineer Shradha Gupta has summited Mount Everest (8,849 metres) — the highest point on Earth — completing one of the most demanding achievements in high-altitude climbing.

The ascent was undertaken with Elite Expeditions, the company founded by record-breaking mountaineer Nirmal Purja. The summit marks the most significant milestone yet in Gupta's rapidly rising mountaineering career, which has taken her from recreational hiking in Dubai to the summit of the world's highest mountain in just three years.

Gupta's Everest ascent follows her historic summit of Mount Manaslu (8,163 metres) — the world's eighth-highest mountain — on September 26, last year.

That climb marked her entry into the elite world of 8,000-metre mountaineering and established her as one of India's emerging names in endurance climbing.

Everest, standing at 8,849 metres above sea level in the Himalayas on the Nepal-Tibet border, is the ultimate objective for high-altitude mountaineers worldwide.

The summit sits deep in what climbers call the 'death zone' — the altitude above 8,000 metres where oxygen levels fall to a third of those at sea level, and the human body begins to deteriorate faster than it can recover.

Before her Himalayan expeditions, Gupta had already completed three of the famed Seven Summits — the



Shradha Gupta

highest peaks on each continent. She summited Mount Kilimanjaro (5,895 metres) in Africa, Mount Elbrus (5,642 metres) in Europe, and Aconcagua (6,961 metres) in South America, in addition to completing the trek to Everest Base Camp.

Her progression from the Seven Summits to the 8,000-metre peaks reflects a deliberate, disciplined approach to high-altitude mountaineering — building altitude experience, technical skill, and physiological acclimatisation step by step before taking on the world's most demanding terrain.

What makes Gupta's story particularly compelling is the trajectory. She entered high-altitude climbing only about three years ago, after rediscovering her passion for the outdoors following the pandemic.

In that short span, she has moved from recreational hiking to standing on the highest point on Earth — a progression that takes most mountaineers a decade or more.

Gupta is a resident of Dubai and heads the Corporate business in the Middle East at DBS Bank, the Singapore-headquartered financial institution.

She started her career in banking with DBS Bank in Singapore in 2006 after completing her Engineering from National University of Singapore. Her mountaineering achievements have been pursued alongside a demanding senior leadership role in international banking — a duality that she embodies and hopes will inspire others who believe transformational goals are only possible outside the pressures of professional life.

I am never part of the crowd: Sanjay Mishra

The veteran actor reveals why Pritha Chakraborty's Bengali debut film struck a personal chord

ANINDITA ACHARYA

You can feel the fatigue in his voice. He is sleep-deprived. He had a late hour on the sets of director Rohit Shetty's 'Golmaal 5'. But then, the moment we talk about films, you can feel his infectious energy. For decades, Mishra has been one of Indian cinema's most versatile performers, moving effortlessly between laugh-out-loud comic roles and intense characters in films like 'Ankhon Dekhi', 'Masaan', 'Kaamy- aab' and 'Vadhi'.

In a hero-centric film industry, Mishra has built a career in portraying ordinary people with extraordinary authenticity. More recently, he impressed audiences as cop Ashok, an aide to Saif Ali Khan, in the web show 'Kartavya'. And now, the veteran actor has impressed one and all in his very first outing in Bengali films. Pritha Chakraborty of 'Mukherjee Dar Bou' fame has returned to direction after seven years on the big screen with 'Phera'. A personal film, it explores the pain, love and emotional complexities of a father-son relationship. Ritwik Chakraborty plays Mishra's son in the film.

The 'Kadvi Hawa' actor had received offers to do Bengali films earlier. But he settled for 'Phera' as his Bengali debut and his reasons seem rooted.

"When I was growing up, I was influenced by the films of Satyajit Ray, Mrinal Sen and Ritwik Ghatak. I wanted to be a part of the kind of life that existed in their films," he said. Mishra stated that Pritha had closely connected the story to her relationship with her father, giving the screenplay an emotional authenticity that resonated with him. 'Phera' also transported him to the days when his father introduced him to Bengali literature, music and thought. Given that exposure, he felt he could naturally under-



stand the emotional nuances required for the film.

Whenever any Bollywood actor works in a regional film, the pronunciation becomes an issue, but not in the case of Mishra. He spoke fluently in Bengali and the multifaceted actor credits Pritha for the accuracy.

"The language was my biggest worry. After 15 days of shooting, we spent another 15 days dubbing the film. Pritha is a gem. You won't believe how much she worked on my language and performance," said the 'Phas Gaya Re Obama' actor.

The actor also keeps himself updated on Bengali cinema. He doesn't mince words when he says the industry drifted away from the quality associated with its golden era in the last few years.

"At one point, I felt something had gone wrong in Bengali cinema. The quality that was once there seemed lost. But now I feel films are again trying to bring back that quality," he observed.

The actor also mentioned how he had an enriching experience working with Ritwik. Heaving praises on the actor, Mishra added, "Actually, it never felt like we were acting. We simply existed together in those moments."

And would he return to Bengali cinema after 'Phera'? Without hesitation, Mishra replied, "If I get another Pritha, I will definitely do it." To this, Pritha, who was also on the call with us, thanked the veteran actor for all the adulation.

As an actor, Mishra polishes his

craft by revisiting the works of cinematic masters. Calling himself a one-man film festival, he said he often watches classics by directors and actors who have influenced him, including Ray and other legends.

In most of his films, be it 'Masaan', 'Ankhon Dekhi' or 'Kaamyaaab', Mishra's ability to connect with ordinary people has been the defining moment. Asked why common men repeatedly attracted him as an actor, Mishra offered a simple explanation.

"I am never really part of a crowd. As an actor, I observe people from a distance because one day I may have to play one of them."

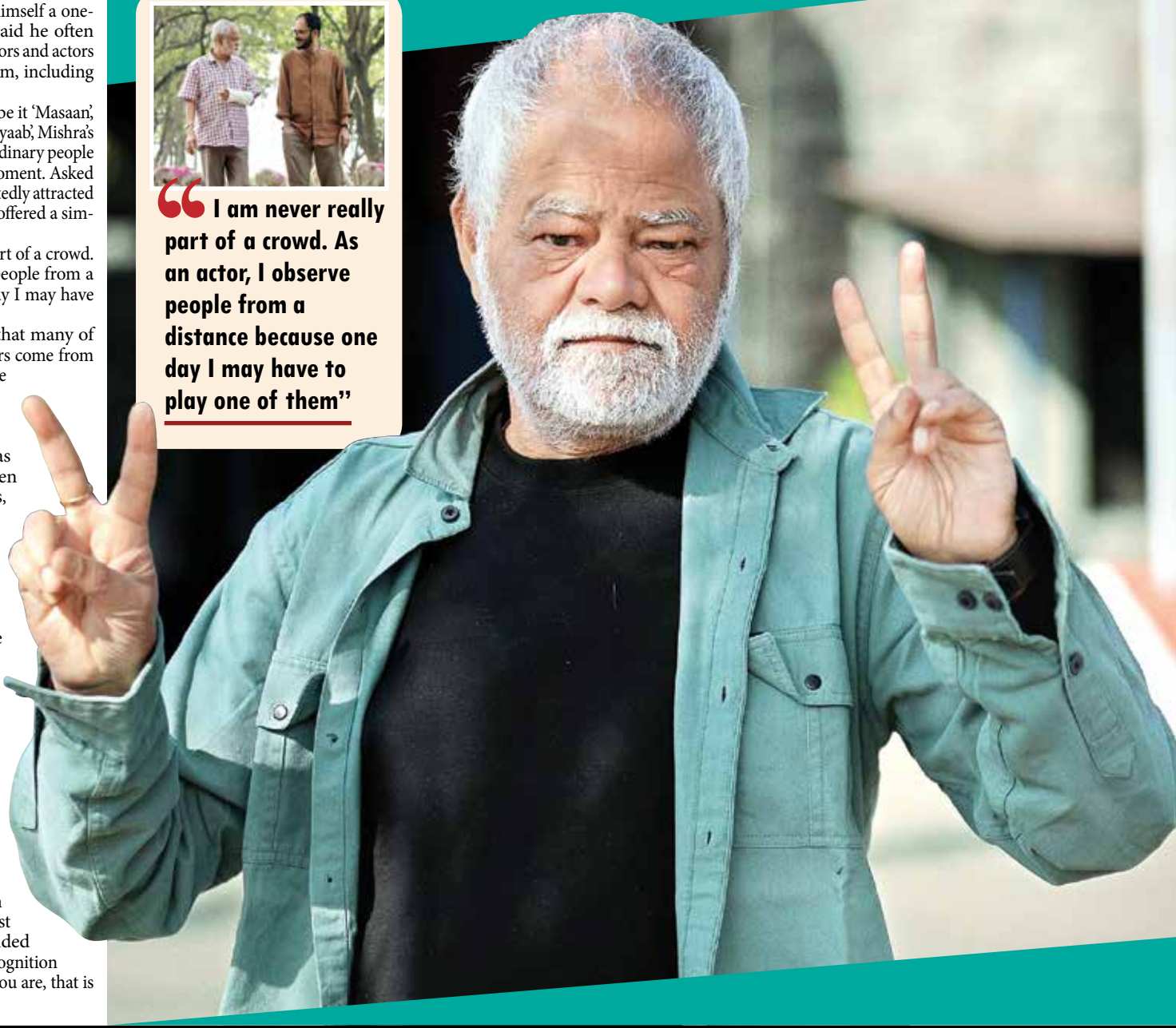
He also explained that many of his memorable characters come from real-life observations. The neighbour, the uncle, the family friend who constantly gives advice... these are people he has known all his life. When he plays such characters, audiences recognise them because they already exist in their own worlds.

Away from the cinema, Mishra's simplicity and grounded nature have often stood out in an era dominated by social media and paparazzi culture. Asked how he remains unaffected by stardom, the actor responded with characteristic humility.

He recalled his film 'Kaamyaaab', where he plays an ageing actor, whose life unfolds within the confines of a modest home. The role reminded him that success and recognition are fleeting. "Whoever you are, that is who you are," he said.



"I am never really part of a crowd. As an actor, I observe people from a distance because one day I may have to play one of them"



Manoj Bajpayee says 'Ghooskhor Pandat' row affected team

MUMBAI: Manoj Bajpayee said the huge controversy over the title of his upcoming film 'Ghooskhor Pandat' affected the entire team for some time, while he himself faced a lot of threats.

The 57-year-old actor said the team promptly responded to the uproar over the title, which was dubbed casteist by many on social media. The new title of the film is yet to be announced. "We didn't expect it. But when it happened, in two days' time, we put out our apology. If anything is offending anyone with that much intensity, we as creative people are always there to mend our ways or correct ourselves. I personally feel that the title change is not going to be such a huge thing. We are creative people; we can come up with 10 different titles and they will be equally exciting," the actor told PTT.

The crime thriller film, directed by Ritesh Shah and produced by filmmaker Neeraj Pandey, was announced by streaming service 'Netflix' in February this year. The film's title sparked a storm on social media.



Emily recalls avoiding AI to record sound effects in 'Disclosure Day'



LOS ANGELES: Hollywood star Emily Blunt said she chose to record the inhuman, alien clicking and breathing sounds in her upcoming film 'Disclosure Day' herself instead of relying on Artificial Intelligence, as she is terrified of it.

Blunt features in Steven Spielberg's film, which is set to release in theatres on June 12. It is produced by 'Universal Pictures'. The actress, who recently featured in 'The Devil Wears Prada 2', said an extra microphone was placed near her throat while recording. She was initially given a choice by the filmmaker to use AI. "Even kind of leading up to that moment where she starts speaking in this non-human language... It's a four-minute one that we shot that leads up to that moment, where she's gradually sort of disintegrating," she said at the 'Hot Ones' talk show.

"There are various ways you could do it. You could go the AI route, which I'm a bit terrified of. I thought I could make some real, really strange sounds. So, I said, 'Maybe I could come in, and we'll just do a range of weird sounds'. And it's what we did. I did sort of the clicking sounds. I did sort of humming, consonant and breathing-strange sounds," she added.

"I thought I could make some real, really strange sounds," says Blunt

MADHURI DIXIT DEFENDS AISHWARYA RAI BACHCHAN AGAINST TROLLS

Aishwarya faced trolling over her appearance at 2026 Cannes Film Festival

Aishwarya Rai Bachchan is a global star who has made her country proud with her achievements, said Madhuri Dixit, coming out in support of her 'Devdas' co-star, who faced trolling over her appearance on the red carpet of the Cannes Film Festival.

Aishwarya, a Cannes regular for more than

two decades, became the target of online trolling and body-shaming after images and vid-

eos from the 2026 red carpet circulated on social media. Madhuri said Aishwarya has built a legacy by representing India on the global stage and trolling her over her appearance sends the wrong message to youngsters.

"She has been going there for 20 years. She has done the whole country proud. She is a global star. As Miss World, she has done so much for the country. You cannot reduce her to a number on a scale or a size on the dress, a size or a number on the calendar years. You cannot reduce her to that. She is beautiful. She looks beautiful, but she is beautiful inside," Madhuri told PTT.

Madhuri and Aishwarya worked together in Sanjay Leela Bhansali's period romance drama 'Devdas' with Shah Rukh Khan. In fact, Aish-



"You cannot reduce her to a number on a scale," says Madhuri

warya first attended Cannes in 2002 for the premiere of the film alongside Shah Rukh. Her appearance on the red carpet in a traditional yellow sari drew widespread attention back then

MASOOM: THE NEW GENERATION

Shekhar Kapur & A R Rahman reunite

The film is set to explore themes of identity, family, love and migration

MUMBAI: Acclaimed filmmaker Shekhar Kapur and Academy Award-winning composer A R Rahman are joining forces for 'Masoom: The New Generation', a contemporary reimagining of Kapur's beloved 1983 classic.

Rahman, who earlier collaborated with Kapur for his Hollywood movie 'Elizabeth: The Golden Age' as well as musical theatre productions 'Bombay Dreams' and 'Why? The Musical' is coming on board not just as composer but also as co-producer.

Directed by Kapur, the film is set to explore themes of identity, family, love and migration through a modern lens while retaining the emotional core of the original.

"For a long time, I've felt that the themes of 'Masoom' deserved to be revisited through the lens of today's world. Families, relationships, identity; these ideas have



evolved so much, and cinema must evolve with them. Rahman has always had the rare ability to create music that speaks directly to the soul of a story and its audience. Having him as both composer and creative partner on this journey makes it even more meaningful," Kapur said.

Rahman said working with Kapur had always been a deeply enriching experience and described him as a men-

tor and creative force. "When he shared the vision for this film, I felt compelled to be involved beyond the music. There's something timeless about 'Masoom' and reinterpreting that emotional world for a new generation feels both exciting and neces-

sary," the composer said. Veteran stars Shabana Azmi and Naseeruddin Shah, who played lead roles in the 1983 film, are set to return for the new film, which will start shooting later this year.

Based on American author Erich Segal's book 'Man, Woman and Child', 'Masoom' was a story

of love, betrayal and the complexities of family. It followed a happily married couple whose lives are upended when the husband's illegitimate son from a past affair enters their home.

Besides Shah and Azmi, 'Masoom: The New Generation' will also feature Manoj Bajpayee, Nithya Menen and Kapur's daughter Kaveri Kapur

